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Imperial Talismanic Love: Ibn Turka's *Debate of Feast and Fight* (1426) as Philosophical Romance and Lettrist Mirror for Timurid Princes

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Abstract: This study presents and intellectual- and literary-historically contextualizes a remarkable but as yet unpublished treatise by Ibn Turka (d. 1432), foremost occult philosopher of Timurid Iran: the *Munāẓara-yi bazm u razm*. As its title indicates, this ornate Persian work, written in 1426 in Herat for the Timurid prince-calligrapher Bāysunghur (d. 1433), takes the form of a literary debate, a venerable Arabo-Persian genre that exploded in popularity in the post-Mongol period. Yet it triply transgresses the bounds of its genre, and doubly marries Arabic-Mamluk literary and imperial culture to Persian-Timurid. For here Ibn Turka recasts the *munāẓara* as philosophical romance and the philosophical romance as mirror for princes, imperializing the *razm u bazm* and sword vs. pen tropes within an expressly *lettrist* framework, making explicit the logic of the *coincidentia oppositorum* (*majmaʿ al-aḍḍād*) long implicit in the genre in order to ideologically weaponize it. For the first time in the centuries-old Arabo-Persian *munāẓara* tradition, that is, wherein such debates were often rhetorically but never theoretically resolved, Ibn Turka marries multiple opposites in a manner clearly meant to be instructive to his Timurid royal patron: he is to perform the role of Emperor Love (*sulṭān ʿishq*), transcendent of all political-legal dualities, avatar of the divine names the Manifest (*al-ẓāhir*) and the Occult (*al-bāṭin*). This lettrist mirror for Timurid princes is thus not simply unprecedented in Persian or indeed Arabic literature, a typical expression of the ornate literary panache and genre-hybridizing proclivities of Mamluk-Timurid-Ottoman scientists of letters, and index of the burgeoning of Ibn ʿArabian-Būnian lettrism in late Mamluk Cairo; it also serves as key to Timurid universalist imperial ideology itself in its formative phase – and consciously epitomizes the principle of *contradiction* driving Islamicate civilization as a whole.

To show the striking extent to which this *munāẓara* departs from precedent, I provide a brief overview of the sword vs. pen subset of that genre; I then

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examine our text's specific political-philosophical and sociocultural contexts, with attention to Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī's (d. 1274) *Akhlāq-i Nāṣirī* and Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī's (d. 1502) *Akhlāq-i Jalālī* on the one hand – which seminal Persian mirrors for princes assert, crucially, the ontological-political primacy of love over justice – and the *Ẓafarnāma* of Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī (d. 1454), Ibn Turka's student and friend, on the other. In the latter, much-imitated history Amir Temūr (r. 1370–1405) was definitively transformed, on the basis of astrological and lettrist proofs, into the supreme Lord of Conjunction (*ṣāhib-qirān*); most notably, there Yazdī theorizes the Muslim world conqueror as historical manifestation of the *coincidentia oppositorum* – precisely the project of Ibn Turka in his *Debate of Feast and Fight*. But these two ideologues of Timurid universal imperialism and leading members of the New Brethren of Purity network only became such in Mamluk Cairo, where lettrism (*ʿilm al-ḥurūf*) was first *sanctified*, *de-esoterized* and *adabized*; I accordingly invoke the overtly occultist-neopythagoreanizing ethos specific to the Mamluk capital by the late 14th century, especially that propagated at the court of Barqūq (r. 1382–1399). For it is this Cairene ethos, I argue, that is epitomized by our persophone lettrist's *munāẓara*, which it effectively *timuridizes*. To demonstrate the robustness of this Mamluk-Timurid ideological-literary continuity, I situate the *Munāẓara-yi bazm u razm* within Ibn Turka's own oeuvre and imperial ideological program, successively developed for the Timurid rulers Iskandar Sulṭān (r. 1409–1414), Shāhrukh (r. 1409–1447) and Ulugh Beg (r. 1409–1449); marshal three contemporary instances of the sword vs. pen *munāẓara*, one Timurid and two Mamluk, by the theologian Sayyid Sharīf Jurjānī (d. 1413), the secretary-encyclopedist Aḥmad al-Qalqashandī (d. 1418) and the historian Ibn Khaldūn (d. 1406), respectively; and provide an abridged translation of Ibn Turka's offering as basis for comparative analysis.

Keywords: Ibn Turka, lettrism, literary debate (*munāẓara*), sword vs. pen, Persian mirrors for princes, philosophical romance, Lord of Conjunction (*ṣāhib-qirān*), Timurid imperial ideology, Mamluk-Timurid Arabo-Persian literary culture, *coincidentia oppositorum*

Sword e'er contended with its foe the pen –
the two now made one by their blessed sovereign.
*Qaṭrān Tabrizī*¹

They do not comprehend how a thing agrees at variance with itself; it is an attunement
turning back on itself, like that of the bow and the lyre.
*Heraclitus*²

Everything that happens, when it has significance, is in the nature of a contradiction.
*Henry Miller*³

He is the First and the Last, the Manifest and the Occult.
Qur'ān 57:3

Introduction: Singing the *Ṣāhib-Qirān*

How to tell the tale of a world-conquering Lord of Conjunction (*ṣāhib-qirān*)? The bards of the Persian cosmopolis roundly agreed: one must sing, preferably at great length and in infinite permutation, of the magnificent debauchery of his boozing and the horrific carnage of his battling, his feats in the arenas of love and sorcery, his subjugations of sword and pen. And so they sang, from Firdawsī (d. ca. 1020) onward, progressively synthesizing ancient Iranian imperial tropes with new Arabo-Islamic ones, celebrating imperial heroes like Rustam, Alexander and 'Alī in equal measure.⁴

Representative of this process was the transformation of Ḥamza b. 'Abd al-Muṭṭalib (d. 625), the Prophet's uncle, into paradigmatic model: the epic of Amir Ḥamza, Lord of Conjunction, conqueror of the world and spreader of Islam to India, was one of the most popular of the persophone world down to the 20th

1 *Khilāf būd hamisha miyān-i tigh u qalam / kunūn bi bakht-i malik muttafiq shudand bi ham: Dīvān* (Tehran: Fardīn, 1362 hš/1983), 231 (translation mine); cited in Firuza ABDULLAEVA, "The Origins of the *Munāẓara* Genre in New Persian Literature," in *Metaphor and Imagery in Persian Poetry*, ed. Ali Asghar Seyed-Gohrab, Leiden: Brill, 2012, 269.

2 Charles H. KAHN, *The Art and Thought of Heraclitus: An Edition of the Fragments with Translation and Commentary*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1979, 65.

3 *Tropic of Capricorn*, New York: Grove Press, 1961, 13. My thanks to Andrew Berns for this reference.

4 On the explosion in popularity of Persian epics in the post-Mongol period, and their striking thematic shift away from Firdawsian nationalism and toward mystical heroism, see Maṣṣūṭ RAS-TAGĀRFASĀ'Ī, "Ḥamāsa-sarā'ī dar Īrān pas az ḥamla-yi Mughūl tā zuhūr-i Ṣafaviyān," *Āyina-yi mīrās* 41 (Summer 1387 hš/2008): 5–22.

century.⁵ Mirzā Amān ‘Alī Khān Ghālib, the Lucknowi author of a very successful 1855 Urdu version of this romance – hailed as “[t]he *Iliad* and *Odyssey* of medieval Persia, a rollicking, magic-filled heroic saga” in *The New York Times* book review of Musharraf Ali Farooqi’s Modern Library translation⁶ – provides the reader with a formal typology of the genre in the preface to his *Tarjuma-yi Dāstān-i Šāhib-Qirān*: “There are four elements to this tale: fight and feast, talismans and trickery” (is *dāstān meḥ cār cizen haiḥ: razm bazm ṭilism aur ‘ayyārī*).⁷ This typology slightly modifies that given two and a half centuries before by ‘Abd al-Nabī Fakhr al-Zamānī (d. 1632), a Qazvīnī litterateur in service to the Mughal emperor Jahāngīr (r. 1605–1627), who authored the first extant handbook on the professional art of storytelling (*qışsa-khwānī*), *Embroidering Tales* (*Ṭirāz al-akhbār*). Canonizing the preceding centuries of Persian epic storytelling, this work identifies the four basic elements of a Lord of Conjunction tale as being rather fight and feast (*razm u bazm*), loveplay and trickery (*‘āshiqī u ‘ayyārī*), and provides many poetic models for each.⁸

5 Ḥamza “was a childhood playmate and foster brother of the Prophet who died during the latter’s life in the battle of Uhud in 625” (A. Azfar MOIN, *The Millennial Sovereign: Sacred Kingship and Sainthood in Islam*, New York: Columbia University Press, 2012, 46; on his transformation into Lord of Conjunction see *ibid.*, 45–46; on Temūr’s similar transformation see *ibid.*, 23–55). For a recent overview of the historical development of the title *šāhib-qirān* in the Persianate world and definitive association with Temūr see Christopher A. MARKIEWICZ, “The Crisis of Rule in Late Medieval Islam: A Study of Idrīs Bidlīsī (861–926/1457–1520) and Kingship at the Turn of the Sixteenth Century,” Ph.D. dissertation, University of Chicago, 2015, 311–317.

6 *The Adventures of Amir Hamza: Lord of the Auspicious Planetary Conjunction*, trans. Musharraf Ali Farooqi, New York: Modern Library, 2008. That this Urdu version opens with a description of the Sasanid shah Qubād’s (r. 488–531) 40 viziers as having such total mastery of geomancy, lettrism and astrology as to put Galen, Euclid and Pythagoras to shame (*ibid.*, 3) is indicative of its post-Mongol Persianate origin (see Matthew MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “Astrology, Lettrism, Geomancy: The Occult-Scientific Methods of Post-Mongol Islamicate Imperialism,” *Medieval History Journal* 19/1 (2016): 142–150).

7 *Tarjuma-yi Dāstān-i Šāhib-Qirān*, Calcutta: Maṭba‘a-yi Imdādiyya, 1855, 2.

8 On both texts see Pasha M. KHAN, “A Handbook for Storytellers: The *Ṭirāz al-akhbār* and the *Qissa* Genre,” in *Tellings and Texts: Music, Literature and Performance in North India*, ed. Francesca Orsini and Katherine Butler Schofield, Cambridge: Open Book, 2015, 185–207; on the first see Muḥammad-Riżā SHAFĪ‘Ī-KADKANĪ, “Nigāhī bi *Ṭirāz al-akhbār*,” *Nāma-yi Bahārīstān* 5/1 (1381 hš/2002): 109–122; for their larger context see Pasha Mohamad KHAN, “The Broken Spell: The Romance Genre in Late Mughal India,” Ph.D. dissertation, Columbia University, 2013, forthcoming as *The Broken Spell: Indian Storytelling and the Romance Genre in Persian and Urdu*, Detroit: Wayne State University Press, 2019. On Safavid *bazm u razm* practices in particular see Rudi MATTHEE, *The Pursuit of Pleasure: Drugs and Stimulants in Iranian History, 1500–1900*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2005, 48–61; on the *bazm* alone as a stable imperial practice and crucial tool of diplomacy from the Sasanid period to the Ghaznavid see A. S. MELIKIAN-CHIRVANI, “The Iranian *Bazm* in Early Persian Sources,” in *Banquets d’Orient*, ed. Rika Gyselen and

Fakhr al-Zamānī's category of *'āshiqī*, loveplay, thus becomes with Ghālib Lakhnawī *ṭilism*, talismans, sorcery, enchantment.⁹ Given the highly formalized and largely stable nature of the genre as practiced for a full millennium, this substitution reflects not a thematic shift between the 17th and 19th centuries, I argue, but rather provides us with a crucial insight into the theoretical mechanics of *ṣāhib-qirān*-hood and the discourse of Islamic universalist imperialism in the post-Mongol period. To wit: only *talismanic Love*, incarnated in a Lord of Conjunction, can create world empire.

Ibn Turka and the Sword vs. Pen *Munāẓara* Tradition

Such is the explicit moral of a remarkable Timurid instance of the *razm u bazm* genre: Ṣā'in al-Dīn 'Alī Turka Iṣfahānī's (d. 1432) *Debate of Feast and Fight* (*Munāẓara-yi bazm u razm*). Produced in 1426 in Herat for the Timurid prince-calligrapher Bāysunghur b. Shāhrukh b. Temür (d. 1433), this ornate Persian work takes the form of a *munāẓara*, or literary debate, a vital genre in the Arabo-Persian literary tradition from its inception, with deep roots in Near Eastern and classical antiquity, and utterly mainstream by the 15th century.¹⁰ Formally, Ibn Turka's offering belongs to the popular sword vs. pen (*al-sayf wa-l-qalam*) subset of that genre; this theme is unique to Arabo-Persian letters, and signifies, in sociopoliti-

Marthe Bernus-Taylor, Bures-sur-Yvette: Groupe pour l'Étude de la Civilisation du Moyen-Orient, 1992, 95–118.

⁹ Ghālib Lakhnawī's emphasis on *magic*, and hence *imagination*, as being at the core of the romance genre was to offend subsequent Urdu literary critics, thoroughly autocolonialist in their embrace of Enlightenment "rationalism" and "realism" and scorn for endarkened Islamic "irrationalism" (KHAN, "The Broken Spell," 6–35). On early modern Islamic occultism as the *Triply Other* – and hence the urgent moral need to decolonize its study – see Matthew MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "(De)colonizing Early Modern Occult Philosophy," *Magic, Ritual, and Witchcraft* 12/1 (2017): 98–112.

¹⁰ See e.g. Geert Jan VAN GELDER, "The Conceit of Pen and Sword: On an Arabic Literary Debate," *Journal of Semitic Studies* 32/2 (1987): 329–360; John N. MATTOCK, "The Arabic Tradition: Origin and Developments," in *Dispute Poems and Dialogues in the Ancient and Medieval Near East*, ed. G. J. Reinink and H. I. J. Vanstiphout, Leuven: Peeters, 1991, 153–163; Adrian GULLY, "The Sword and the Pen in the Pre-Modern Arabic Heritage: A Literary Representation of an Important Historical Relationship," in *Ideas, Images, and Methods of Portrayal: Insights into Classical Arabic Literature and Islam*, ed. Sebastian Günther, Leiden: Brill, 2005, 401–430; ABDULLAEVA, "The Origins."

cal terms, the military and the bureaucracy respectively. Debates between sword and pen became especially popular in the Mongol and post-Mongol period,¹¹ this due to their perennial usefulness in attracting elite patronage, naturally, but also as a vehicle for political theory (particularly in ethics literature) in the postcaliph era – as with the specimen here in view. Among the many and varied works in this vein, however, Ibn Turka's stands out as exceptional: for it is the first in the tradition to be explicitly couched in *occult-scientific*, and specifically *lettrist*, terms, and that as basis for Islamic universalist imperialism.

To understand the striking extent to which our *munāẓara* departs from precedent, a brief overview of the genre is necessary, together with the text's specific political-philosophical and sociocultural contexts; contemporary Timurid and Mamluk examples will also be marshaled below. As this work has yet to be published or studied, moreover, I then provide an abridged translation as basis for my comparative analysis.¹²

The first sword vs. pen debate in Arabic is that of the Andalusī litterateur Ibn Burd the Younger (d. 1053), an ornate prose work eulogizing the Denian-Majorcan ruler al-Muwaffaq Mujāhid al-ʿĀmirī (r. ca. 1012–1045),¹³ and the first in New Persian a *qaṣīda* by the Seljuq poet-laureate Amīr Muʿizzī (d. 1148) eulogizing Sultan Sanjar (r. 1097–1157).¹⁴ Unlike other *munāẓaras*, such as those between two animals, plants, beverages, implements, cities, regions, religions, ethnicities, etc., usually characterized by literary historians as “exercises in scholarly frivolity” and mere “entertainments,”¹⁵ sword vs. pen debates served a more serious purpose:¹⁶ they functioned primarily as panegyric (*madḥ*), whereby the royal dedicatee played judge between the two competing factions, and often uniting both in his transcendent person (as in Ibn Burd's and Muʿizzī's inaugural versions).¹⁷ Thus, for example, Qaṭrān Tabrīzī's (d. 1072) *qaṣīda* in eulogy of his royal patron Abū l-Muʿammar, the opening line from which was provided as epigram

11 Louise MARLOW, *Hierarchy and Egalitarianism in Islamic Thought*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997, 172.

12 For a full translation and edition see my forthcoming *The Lettrist Treatises of Ibn Turka: Reading and Writing the Cosmos in the Timurid Renaissance*.

13 For an analysis see VAN GELDER, “The Conceit”, 348–351.

14 Ghulām-Ḥusayn GHULĀM-ḤUSAYNZĀDA et al., “Dirāsa muqārīna li-munāẓarāt al-sayf wa-l-qalam bayn al-adabayn al-ʿarabī wa-l-fārisī: al-Yaʿqūbī al-Ṭūsī wa-Ibn Nubāta al-Miṣrī numūdhajan,” *Majallat al-ʿUlūm al-Insāniyya al-Duwalliyya* 18/4 (1432/2011): 23.

15 MATTOCK, “The Arabic Tradition,” 154.

16 So argues Adrian GULLY, emphasizing the consequent need for sociohistorical contextualization (“The Sword and the Pen,” 409).

17 This reflects the early fusion of the *munāẓara* genre as a whole with that of the *qaṣīda*, itself comprising *madḥ*, *fakhr* and *hajw/hijāʾ* (ABDULLAEVA, “The Origins,” 252). It should be noted in

above; and thus does Asadī Tūsī (d. 1073) hail his noble patron in the conclusion to his debate between an Arab and a Persian (*Munāẓara-yi ‘Arab u ‘Ajam*):

A nobleman whose valor spreads danger and punishment
with eloquent sword and shining pen!¹⁸

But such a resolution is only one of three possible outcomes in true *munāẓaras* of this type: “The conflict may end either undecided, or with a clear victory of one of the contestants, or with a reconciliation.”¹⁹ Indeed, a certain *imbalance* was inherent in the subgenre from its genesis, for in a literary-textual context pen must always have an unfair advantage over sword; and the sword vs. pen trope itself would seem to go back to such sources as the saying attributed to Alexander: “This world’s affairs are determined by two things only, and one of them is inferior to the other: they are the sword and the pen, and the sword is inferior to the pen.”²⁰ But many *munāẓara* authors contrived to balance them nonetheless.

The Ilkhanid historian Ibn al-Ṭīqṭaqā (d. ca. 1309) summarizes the genre’s three options as follows:

The realm is guarded by the sword and administered by the pen. There is difference of opinion concerning which of the two, the sword or the pen, is superior and more worthy of favour (*taqdīm*). One group considers the pen dominant over the sword; they argue that the sword protects the pen, and is therefore its guardian and servant; another group considers the sword to be dominant and argues that the pen serves the sword, because it procures sustenance for those who wield swords, as a servant would. Another group maintains that the two are equal, and that neither one can dispense with the other.²¹

It is Ibn al-Ṭīqṭaqā’s third option that was roundly embraced by authors of mirrors for princes, who frequently “portray the military and bureaucratic functions in government as partners, neither of the pair being able to dispense with the other.”²² Another venerable genre with roots in Sasanid advice (*andarz*) literature, Arabic and Persian mirrors for princes typically exhort their elite dedicatees to master sword and pen in equal measure, both through patronage and in

this connection that Mu‘izzī in particular frequently deployed the term *ṣāhib-qirān* in praise of Seljuq rulers and governors (DIHKHUDĀ, *Lughatnāma*, s.v.).

¹⁸ *Ḥurri ki shajā‘at khaṭar afzūd u siyāsāt / az tigh-i dur-afshānī u kilk-i zar-afshān*. The line is given without citation and mistranslated in ABDULLAEVA, “The Origins,” 269. Asadī’s debates are the earliest extant in New Persian.

¹⁹ VAN GELDER, “The Conceit,” 330.

²⁰ *Ibid.*, 337, 351.

²¹ *K. al-Fakhrī* (Cairo, 1371/1952), 45–46; trans. in MARLOW, *Hierarchy*, 171.

²² *Ibid.*

their own person, combining therein the virtues of dread conqueror and beloved philosopher-king. Only through such reconciliation, such harmonization, such *balance* ('*adl*) can an Islamic imperium flourish.

So advises Ibn Turka in his *Debate of Feast and Fight*; but the balance he describes is not psychological or sociological, but *cosmic*. Where mirrors for princes and sword vs. pen *munāẓaras* portray a single reconciliation between the two factions as the engine of justice ('*adl*) – and hence the Circle of Justice, that foundation of all Islamic political philosophy –, the Isfahani lettrist portrays a double sociopolitical marriage, achievable only through imperial-metaphysical love: *sultān 'ishq*. Thus the 'masters of sword and pen' (*arbāb-i sayf u qalam*) are for him, uniquely, not two factions but one, united as manifestation of the divine name *the Manifest* (*al-zāhir*), embodying empire and the majesty (*jalāl*) of God; their counterparts are the literary and scholarly elites of the court's inner sanctum, the sultan's boon companions (sg. *nadīm*), united as manifestation of the divine name *the Occult* (*al-bāṭin*), embodying enlightenment and the beauty (*jamāl*) of God.²³ Eternally do they contend one with the other as ontological opposites must – yet these opposites are eternally married by Emperor Love, supreme Lord of Conjunction. (Which is to say: of auspicious horoscope simultaneously stable and revolutionary, Alexandrian encompasser of East and West, talismanic nexus of heaven and earth.) The cosmological accuracy of this paradigm is moreover subject to occult-scientific proof; the *munāẓara* accordingly ends with a lettrist analysis of the terms *bazm* and *razm*.²⁴ To create a world empire, in short, is to harness and reprise the eternal, emanative process of creation itself, is to incarnate the quranic dictum *He is the First and the Last, the Manifest and the Occult* (Q 57:3); and the engine of that process is not justice, but love.

Love vs. Justice in Persian Mirrors for Princes

Ibn Turka's love-centric formulation has no precedent in the Arabo-Persian *munāẓara* tradition; for this we must turn to Persian mirrors for princes. The most influential of these in the post-Mongol Persianate world was Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī's (d. 1274) *Akhlāq-i Nāṣirī*, which served as model for most subsequent instances of the genre, including in the first place Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī's (d. 1502) *Lavāmi'*

²³ Ibn Turka's invocation of the majesty vs. beauty trope here signals, of course, his commitment to Ibn 'Arabian metaphysics; see below.

²⁴ In lettrist theory, from Jābir b. Ḥayyān onward, the name of a thing is an aperture onto its ontological status, temporal fate and even elemental composition.

al-ishrāq fī makārim al-akhlāq, aka *Akhlāq-i Jalālī*, and Ḥusayn Vā'iz Kāshifī's (d. 1505) *Akhlāq-i Muḥsinī*.²⁵ (It is highly significant in this context that the latter two authors were the two most influential letrists of late Timurid-Aqquyunlu Iran.) Therein Ṭūsī broaches, though only briefly, a similar theme: justice may be the pivot of the world – but its ground is love.²⁶ In this he breaks with his own model, Miskawayh's (d. 1030) landmark *Tahdhīb al-akhlāq*, wherein aristotelian-platonic-pythagorean justice remains categorically superior to love.²⁷

Closely following the Ilkhanid philosopher-scientist and like him citing the ancients, Davānī rephrases the same argument, declaring love to be natural and primal, but justice artificial and secondary – indeed, 'justice' (*inṣāf*) derives etymologically from 'half' (*niṣf*) and is therefore the engine of duality (*isnayniyyat*) and division. The descent from unicity (*vaḥdat*) to multiplicity (*kaṣrat*) is of course necessary to the creation of a cosmos, but humanity's goal as composite spiritual-physical beings must be to return (*ma'ād*) or reascend, through unveiling (*kashf*), to the One beyond all unities. Only love can overcome duality, the genesis of alienating multiplicity.²⁸

Given its status as the immediate political-philosophical context for Ibn Turka's argument above, I translate below the relevant passage, opening the second chapter, entitled "On the Excellence of Love" (*dar faẓīlat-i maḥabbat*), of the third book of the *Akhlāq-i Jalālī*:

It has been established that individual human perfection is dependent on society (*ijtimā'*) and affection (*ta'alluf*), which in turn is predicated on love (*maḥabbat*) and companionship (*ulfat*). Since justice is unnecessary where love exists, as was discussed above, love is superior to justice. For love produces a unicity (*vaḥdat*) that is natural (*ṭabī'ī*), justice one that is artificial (*ṣinā'ī*); and it is evident that the natural precedes the artificial. Love does away with the properties of duality (*isnayniyyat*), thereby doing away with any need for

²⁵ On the former work see Christian JAMBET, "Idéal du politique et politique idéal selon Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī," in *Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī: Philosophie et savant du XIII^e siècle*, ed. Nasrollah Pourjavady and Živa Vesel, Tehran: Presses Universitaires d'Iran and Institut Français de Recherche en Iran, 2000, 31–57; on the latter work see Maria E. SUBTELNY, "A Late Medieval Persian *Summa* on Ethics: Kashifī's *Akhlāq-i Muḥsinī*," *Iranian Studies* 36/4 (2003): 601–614. Kashifī's ethics was to be a particularly important source for the hybridizing *qīṣṣa/dāstān* or romance genre; on this interpenetration see KHAN, "The Broken Spell," 176–201.

²⁶ *Akhlāq-i Nāṣirī*, ed. Muṭtabā Minuvī and 'Alī-Riẓā Ḥaydarī, Tehran: Intishārāt-i Khwārazmī, 1356 hš/1976, 258–259.

²⁷ This departure aside, the relevant section of Ṭūsī's work (Book 3, Part 2: 'On the Excellence of Love' (*dar faẓīlat-i maḥabbat*)) otherwise draws frequently on Miskawayh's fifth chapter, 'Love and Friendship' (*al-maḥabba wa-l-ṣadāqa*). On this theme in the early modern Persianate context see Mana KIA's forthcoming *Forms of Companionship: Love, Loyalty and Difference*.

²⁸ *Akhlāq-i Jalālī*, ed. 'Abd Allāh Mas'ūdī Ārānī, Tehran: Intishārāt-i Ittīlā'āt, 1391 hš/2012, 89, 106–107, 225.

justice (*‘adālat*). [The term] justice (*inṣāf*) literally means ‘to divide in two’; hence it is only applicable to matters that are in dispute, in which case a just person divides things equally between himself and his fellow. Such a procedure derives from the principle of multiplicity (*kaṣrat*). But when a relation of union (*ittiḥād*) is established, recourse to [multiplicity] is no longer necessary.

The ancient sages (*qudamā-yi ḥukamā*) held that existents (*mawjūd*) subsist through love, and that every existent must harbor some degree of love in the same way that it has some degree of existence and unicity. It is for this reason that in physical modulations such as hotness or coldness one senses a resistance toward its opposite, and in vegetable or mineral natures [a propensity for] defending against assault may be observed. The elements (*‘anāṣir*) evince an inclination toward the realms of nature (*aḥyāz-i ṭabī‘at*), and even the heavenly spheres (*aflāk*) manifest voluntary orbital motion, the source of this desire (*‘ishq*) being the substance of the Intellect (*jawhar-i ‘aql*) and the [spheres’] longing (*shawq*) to approach it, as philosophers have established. The differences that obtain between existents in terms of degrees of perfection or deficiency thus manifest according to the degree to which the lights of love radiate or are hidden. For love, the shadow (*ẓill*) of oneness, entails permanence and perfection, while strife (*ghalaba*), produced by multiplicity, gives rise to deficiency and disorder. The philosophers holding such a view are called the camp of Love and Strife,²⁹ but other philosophers [similarly] assert that love pervades all engendered beings (*kā’ināt*), as was discussed above.

Eternal love’s secret pervades all things;
were it not so, the lovelorn nightingale
would hardly serenade the rose.³⁰

Despite a pragmatic insistence on the rigidly hierarchical ordering of society and the need for royal absolutism, then, Davānī’s (and Ṭūsī’s) staunchly neoplatonic political philosophy takes on a utopian and implicitly occultist cast through its emphasis on love and harmonious correspondence (*munāsabat*). For if occult

²⁹ On the empedoclean doctrine of Love and Strife see Joel L. KRAEMER, *Humanism in the Renaissance of Islam: The Cultural Revival during the Buyid Age*, Leiden: Brill, 1992, 141–143; and John WALBRIDGE, *The Leaven of the Ancients: Suhrawardī and the Heritage of the Greeks*, Albany: SUNY Press, 2000, 48–51.

³⁰ *Akhlāq-i Jalālī*, 225–226. The continuation of the passage, however, offers a proviso (*ibid.*, 226):

In the terminological usage of latter-day philosophers (*muta’akhhirān*), [the term] love cannot be invoked in cases where the faculty of the intellect is not involved, and they do not term love or hatred the attraction of the elements to the natural realm or the mutual attraction of compounds (*murakkabāt*) due to temperamental concordance (*tanāsib-i mizājī*), as with iron and magnets, or their mutual repulsion due to temperamental discordance (*tabā-yun-i mizājī*), as with the vinegar-repelling stone (*sang-i bāghiz al-khall u sirka*) and the like, but rather attraction (*mayl*) and repulsion (*harab*), and the agreeability or contentiousness of dumb beasts (*ḥayavānāt-i ‘ujm*) they term familiarity (*ulfat*) and aversion (*nafrat*).

science is precisely the harnessing and manipulation of such cosmic relationships (thus routinely defined in contemporary classifications of the sciences), then its proper deployment at the imperial level can be productive of the *siyāsat-i fāzila*, or Fārābīan just, balanced, harmonious society; and that society must be founded on love, the engine of unity and cohesion. But Davānī does not here further develop this theme, or discuss political magic (this he does elsewhere);³¹ like most of his predecessors and successors, the Aqquyunlu philosopher declares his work as a whole to be but an explication of the Circle of Justice. Love and justice thus forever remain in tension, and together make civilization possible.³²

His invocation of the ancients here is not empty: Davānī's love is that of Empedocles, fused with the erotic motion of Plotinus.³³ This doctrine was fully islamicized by the 10th century, when the Brethren of Purity declared in their 37th treatise on love, embracing the Plotinian position: "Divine wisdom and solicitude has bound all existents together with a single bond and strung them together in a single arrangement"; "God is the First Beloved, and the celestial sphere revolves solely out of longing (*shawq*) for Him and love (*maḥabba*) for permanence."³⁴ Likewise, in his *Treatise on Love* (*R. fī l-'Ishq*), even Ibn Sinā (d. 1037), second father of peripateticism, posits love as a primary ground of being, and intrinsic to the divine essence: "Love is the manifestation of both essence (*al-dhāt*) and existence (*al-wujūd*), that is, in the Good (*al-khayr*); the being of existents is therefore either by reason of the love in them [for the Good], or identical to love itself."³⁵ As for Suhrawardī, though his own Persian allegory on the same theme (*R. fī Ḥaqīqat al-'ishq*, aka *Mu'nis al-'ushshāq*) does not similarly valorize love, which

31 For an edition, translation and study of Davānī's *Tuḥfa-yi rūḥānī fī khavāṣṣ al-ḥurūf*, a treatise on practical lettrism and its political applications written for a Khalji sultan of central India, see my forthcoming *The Occult Science of Empire in Aqquyunlu-Safavid Iran: Two Shirazi Lettrists and Their Manuals of Magic*.

32 This, again, nevertheless represents a theoretical departure from mirrors-for-princes precedent, which was strictly justice-centric: "[T]he keynote of the formulations of government in the mirrors for princes was justice, understood not as legal justice but as the harmonious relationship of society in a divinely ordered system, the component parts of which were in perfect equilibrium" (Ann K. S. LAMBTON, "Islamic Mirrors for Princes," in *Atti del Convegno internazionale sul tema: La Persia nel medioevo* (Roma, 31 marzo–5 aprile 1970), Rome: Accademia Nazionale dei Lincei, 1971, 42). On the Circle of Justice see Maria E. SUBTELNY, *Le monde est un jardin: Aspects de l'histoire culturelle de l'Iran médiéval*, Paris: Association pour l'Avancement des Études Iranienues, 2002, 53–76.

33 See Sajjad RIZVI, *Mullā Ṣadrā and Metaphysics: Modulation of Being*, London: Routledge, 2009, 85.

34 *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-Ṣafā'*, 4 vols., Beirut: al-A'lami, 1426/2005, 3/227, 234.

35 Ibn Sinā, *R. fī l-'Ishq*, in idem, *Jāmi' al-badā'i'*, ed. Muḥammad Ḥasan Ismā'il, Beirut: Dār al-Kutub al-'Ilmiyya, 1425/2004, 67.

here plays a subsidiary role equal to that of beauty (*ḥusn*) and sorrow (*ḥuzn*), its siblings,³⁶ in his philosophical *summa*, the *Ḥikmat al-ishrāq*, the father of illuminationism subscribes to the empedoclean doctrine of Love and Strife.³⁷

In the post-Mongol period, however, the philosophical doctrine of love as ground of being came to be most closely associated with Ibn ‘Arabī (d. 1240) – Ibn Turka’s primary point of reference throughout his oeuvre.³⁸ Indeed, the Isfahani occult philosopher is to be considered the most important interpreter of the Shaykh al-Akbar of the first half of the 15th century; and he is emphatic that lettrism, and not sufism, is the key to the Akbarian corpus. (His *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam*, significantly, is the first and only thoroughlygoingly lettrist commentary on that most seminal of texts.³⁹) Nevertheless, Ibn Turka freely deploys such classic sufi phrases, referring to the same concept, as *al-nikāḥ al-sārī fī jamī‘ al-dharārī*, ‘the marriage act pervading all atoms,’ or simply *al-nikāḥ al-sārī*, ‘pervasive coupling,’ and *al-‘aqd al-sā’ir*, ‘perpetual bonding’.⁴⁰ It is this mechanism alone that allows for the union of heaven and earth, the identity of macrocosm and microcosm, upon which neoplatonic emanationist cosmology is predicated. Most famously the stated basis for Isaac Newton’s (d. 1727) theory of gravitation, this doctrine was ubiquitous in early modern Islamo-Christian thought, from the occult philos-

36 It should be noted, however, that Suhrawardī’s *R. fī Ḥaqīqat al-‘ishq* – “a sprawling allegory on the relationships among Beauty, Love, and Sorrow, each of which comes to be for the sake of God’s first creation, the intellect” – cannot be considered an illuminationist allegory, but rather an introductory peripatetic one (WALBRIDGE, *The Leaven*, 108).

37 As he there asserts, using *qahr*, dominance, in place of the standard *ghalaba* (trans. in WALBRIDGE, *The Leaven*, 49): “At the root of the deficient light is passion for the higher light. At the root of the higher light is dominance over the lower light ... Thus, all existence is ordered on the basis of love and dominance.”

38 As a broader cultural and literary category, of course, the post-Mongol Persianate world saw the ascent to hegemony of the School of Love (*madhhab al-‘ishq*). As William CHITTICK remarks in his recent *Divine Love: Islamic Literature and the Path to God* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2013, xi):

Those familiar with the histories and literatures of the Islamic peoples know that love ... is so central to the overall ethos of the religion that if any word can sum up Islamic spirituality – by which I mean the very heart of the Qur’anic message – it should surely be *love*. I used to think that *knowledge* deserved this honor and that the Orientalist Franz Rosenthal had it right in the title of his book *Knowledge Triumphant*. Now I think that *love* does a better job of conveying the nature of the quest for God that lies at the tradition’s heart.

39 See Matthew MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “The Quest for a Universal Science: The Occult Philosophy of Ṣā’in al-Dīn Turka Iṣfahānī (1369–1432) and Intellectual Millenarianism in Early Timurid Iran,” Ph.D. dissertation, Yale University, 2012, 112–113, 379–416. On Ibn Turka’s unprecedentedly sharp distinction between lettrism and sufism see *ibid.*, 315–20, 417–433.

40 *Ibid.*, 364.

ophy of Ibn Turka and the political philosophy of Davānī in the 15th century to the millenarian empiricism of Francis Bacon (d. 1626) in the early 17th.⁴¹

By serving as vehicle for the imperialization of Plotinian-Ibn ‘Arabian erotic motion, in sum, Ibn Turka’s lettrist *Munāẓara-yi bazm u razm*, transcendent of genre boundaries, thus functions as a *neoplatonic-neopythagorean mirror for Timurid princes*.⁴² It is also the only such produced. The first Timurid mirror for princes, *Naṣāyih-i Shāhrukhī*, was composed for Shāhrukh b. Temūr (r. 1409–1447) by Jalāl al-Dīn Qāyīnī (d. 1435), Harātī Ḥanafī traditionist-preacher and vigorous Sunnī proselytizer.⁴³ Significantly, in the *Naṣāyih* Shāhrukh is cast in messianic mold as the *mujaddid* of the 9th Islamic century, a theme developed by subsequent Timurid court historians and challenged by their Aqqyunlu counterparts; these include in the first place Ibn Turka’s student and friend Sharaf al-Dīn ‘Alī Yazdī (d. 1454) and Davānī’s students Faḡl Allāh Khunji Iṣfahānī (d. 1521) and Idrīs Bidlīsī (d. 1520) – all of whom, unlike Qāyīnī, but like Ibn Turka, add lettrist proofs.⁴⁴ (Indeed, Davānī’s *Akhlāq-i Jalālī* itself opens with a lettrist argument for Aqqyunlu imperialism, expressly countering Timurid – that is, Ibn Turkian –

⁴¹ As the latter memorably describes it in his essay on the subject, “Cupid; or the Atom” (*Of the Wisdom of the Ancients*, in idem, *The Works of Francis Bacon*, ed. James Spedding et al., 14 vols., London: Longman, 1861–1879, 6/729–730):

The fable [of Cupid, or Love,] relates to the cradle and infancy of nature, and pierces deep. This Love I understand to be the appetite or instinct of primal matter; or to speak more plainly, *the natural motion of the atom*; which is indeed the original and unique force that constitutes and fashions all things out of matter ... [T]he summary law of nature, that impulse of desire impressed by God upon the primary particles of matter which makes them come together, and which by repetition and multiplication produces all the variety of nature, is a thing which mortal thought may glance at, but can hardly take in.

⁴² Through the efforts of al-Bisṭāmī in particular, Ibn ‘Arabī himself was adopted as patron saint of the Ottoman Empire and theoretical source for its henological imperialism; the Ps.-Ibn ‘Arabian *al-Shajara al-nu‘māniyya fī l-dawla al-‘uthmāniyya* (late 15th or early 16th century?) in particular was embraced as ratification of the Ottoman conquest of the Mamluk Sultanate and claim to being the last world empire (Cornell H. FLEISCHER, “Ancient Wisdom and New Sciences: Prophecies at the Ottoman Court in the Fifteenth and Early Sixteenth Centuries,” in *Falnama: The Book of Omens*, ed. Massumeh Farhad and Serpil Bağcı, London: Thames & Hudson, 2009, 239). See also Denis GRIL, “L’énigme de la *Şağara al-nu‘māniyya fī l-dawla al-‘uthmāniyya*, attribuée à Ibn ‘Arabī,” in *Les Traditions apocalyptiques au tournant de la chute de Constantinople*, ed. Benjamin Lellouch and Stefanos Yerasimos, Paris: Harmattan, 1999, 133–152.

⁴³ On this work and author see Maria Eva SUBTELNY and Anas B. KHALIDOV, “The Curriculum of Islamic Higher Learning in Timurid Iran in the Light of the Sunni Revival under Shāh-Rukh,” *JAOS* 115/2 (1995): 210–236.

⁴⁴ İ. Evrim BİNBAŞ, *Intellectual Networks in Timurid Iran: Sharaf al-Dīn ‘Alī Yazdī and the Islamic Republic of Letters*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2016, 202, 262–265, 286;

arguments in the same vein.⁴⁵) Completed by 1417, Qāyini's work thus predates Ibn Turka's, also written in Herat for the benefit of Shāhrukh (via Bāysunghur),⁴⁶ by some nine years. But the former is certainly not *lettrist*; and the comparatively conservative, legalist-traditionist Sunnī platform it develops for Timurid religio-political legitimacy was soon definitively displaced by Ibn Turka's universalist *occult-scientific* platform for Timurid saint-philosopher-kingship, which proved to be far more attractive to the millennial sovereigns of the early modern Persianate world.⁴⁷

Iskandar Sulṭān's Sword and Pen

Ibn Turka's sword vs. pen *munāẓara* was not the first such Timurid offering. That distinction goes to Mīr Sayyid Sharīf Jurjānī's (d. 1413) 23-line *qaṣīda* written in eulogy to Iskandar Sulṭān, titled *Fī munāẓarat al-sayf wa-l-qalam*; therein sword and pen do not themselves reconcile but are forcibly married in the person of his Timurid patron. I provide a partial translation below by way of contrast; for its fluent celebration of the Timurid ruler – Ibn Turka's most important and receptive patron, as we shall see – as Alexandrian philosopher-king is standard-issue, and like Qāyini's mirror in no way *lettrist*:

By rule of the sword of fate (*qaṣā*)
and command of the pen of destiny (*qadar*)
does God order the cosmos.

Matthew MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "The Delicate Art of Aggression: Uzun Hasan's *Fathnama* to Qaytbay of 1469", *Iranian Studies* 44/2 (2011): 212; MARKIEWICZ, "The Crisis of Rule," 335–337.

45 On Davānī as Ibn Turkian *lettrist* see Matthew MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "World as (Arabic) Text: Mīr Dāmād and the Neopythagoreanization of Philosophy in Safavid Iran", forthcoming; idem, *The Occult Science of Empire*.

46 The work's content aside, that Shāhrukh was the intended audience here is suggested by an extant letter to him from Ibn Turka stating that the latter will send a copy of a *lettrist* treatise, almost certainly the *Su'l al-mulūk*, similarly written for Bāysunghur, on which see below (MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "The Quest", 141–142).

47 The *Naṣāyih* is thus known to survive in only one copy, that made for Shāhrukh's royal library; on this work see Maria Eva SUBTELNY, "The Sunni Revival under Shāh-Rukh and Its Promoters: A Study of the Connection between Ideology and Higher Learning in Timurid Iran", *Proceedings of the 27th Meeting of Haneda Memorial Hall: Symposium on Central Asia and Iran, August 30, 1993*, Kyoto: Institute of Inner Asian Studies, Kyoto University, 1994, 14–23. For an overview of Timurid mirrors for princes, with emphasis on Ilkhanid-Timurid continuities, see idem, *Turko-Persian Politics and Acculturation in Medieval Iran*, Leiden: Brill, 2007, 103–114.

First sword boldly sharpened its tongue:
 “No being’s substance (*gawhar*) is as pure as mine!
 Whenever I lead armies into battle
 at my hand heads roll at once.
 At the mere thought of my blow the lion forfeits its claws,
 shot through with fear of me the eagle sheds its feathers.
 By the radiance of my being every stratagem is foiled,
 in my inexorable grip are the reins of every kingdom.
 When I have set my face for battle, spewing flame,
 none can escape me – except by giving their head to the wind ...
 In every region I take my enlightening face,
 left and right there accrues to me conquest upon conquest!”

The sword’s cutting assault having only sharpened the pen,
 the latter retorted: “O illustrious commander of strife and evil!
 Who are you to compete with me in the arena of excellence,
 you who are two-faced, hard-hearted, a drinker of blood? ...
 You are but a bloody companion, a highwayman, a thief in the night,
 your watchword but murder and the extirpation of men.
 I, however – from the lustrous jewels I distill
 the wealth of the kingdom extends to great and small ...
 [More:] it is by my office that the concealed contents of the heavenly Tablet
 are to prophets made manifest.
 It is I who epitomizes the dictum *light through blackness*,⁴⁸
 in every loamy land (*savād*) held as dear as bright sight itself (*nūr-i baṣār*)!
 Come, find in my pitchy tracts the water of life –
 I’m like Khizr, not awander like Iskandar!

Forever shall the impress of your sword be upon the world,
 forever shall the verdant gardens of your pen be indwelt.
 Let your rule grasp firmly the sword of aspiration
 and the ink of your pen water the root of your life!⁴⁹

For all its lack of a lettrist bent, however, this *qaṣīda*’s authorship by Jurjānī is significant in this context: it commemorates the great Shirāzī theologian’s connection to Iskandar Sulṭān, who is known to have questioned him on doctrinal

⁴⁸ *Al-nūr fī l-sawād*: originally, ‘the light of vision is in the blackness of the pupil’; the play on words here associates enlightenment with the written word. On similar light/dark oppositional imagery in celebration of Persianate writerly-visual culture see Matthew MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “Of Islamic Grammatology: Ibn Turka’s Lettrist Metaphysics of Light”, *al-‘Uṣūr al-Wuṣṭā* 24 (2016): 92–93.

⁴⁹ Edited in Naṣr Allāh PŪRJAVĀDĪ, “Āṣār-i ‘ulamā-yi bāstāni: Mir Sayyid Sharīf ‘Allāma,” *Ar-maghān* 15/163 (1313 hš/1934): 702–703; my thanks to Hadi Jorati for his assistance with the translation.

matters – including the matter of love. Specifically, in early 1412 the Timurid ruler sent a questionnaire on some twelve theological themes to both Jurjānī and Shāh Ni‘mat Allāh Valī (d. 1431), the equally great ṣūfī master and popularizer of Ibn ‘Arabī (and sometime mentor to and intercessor for Ibn Turka).⁵⁰ In his response, Jurjānī answers question two – what was created first, intellect (‘*aql*) or love (‘*ishq*)? – rather ambiguously, if comprehensively, as follows:⁵¹

According to Jurjānī, the first created thing was a non-existent substance with no abode (*jawhar-i lā-makānī*). The Ṣūfis call it the Supreme Caliph (*khalīfa-yi a‘zam*) and the philosophers call it the First Intellect (‘*aql-i awwal*) and Thales of Miletus identified it as water. Philosophers also argue that there are references or allusions to the First Intellect in the Torah. The Wujūdī Ṣūfis, i.e. those Ṣūfis following Ibn ‘Arabī’s doctrine of *waḥdat al-wujūd*, on the other hand, explain the absolute existence with reference to love. Jurjānī himself argues that the Prophet named three creatures as the first created things: pen, intellect, and light.⁵²

The Shirāzī theologian thus declined to champion any one position on the issue – unlike Ibn Turka, no ṣūfī and as a lettrist certainly no *wujūdī*, who emphatically champions the Ibn ‘Arabian position as to the ontological supremacy of love.

This the latter first did not in the *Munāẓara-yi bazm u razm*, but rather in his much longer and more complex *Munāẓarāt-i khams*, aka ‘*Aql u ‘ishq*, completed in 1405 most probably in Cairo. This popular and much-copied Persian philosophical romance consists of five debates in an ornate narrative style, and is clearly influenced by the allegorical tales of Ibn Sinā and especially Suhrawardī.⁵³ In this narrative the interior human faculties debate one another, in the course of their

50 İ. Evrim BINBAŞ, “Timurid Experimentation with Eschatological Absolutism: Mirzā Iskandar, Shāh Ni‘matullāh Walī, and Sayyid Sharif Jurjānī in 815/1412”, in *Unity in Diversity: Mysticism, Messianism and the Construction of Religious Authority in Islam*, ed. Orkhan Mir-Kasimov, Leiden: Brill, 2014, 277–303. On Ibn Turka’s friendly relations with Shāh Ni‘mat Allāh Valī see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “The Quest”, 51, 137, 141, 224–235.

51 This is part of the first question in Shāh Ni‘mat Allāh Valī’s version (BINBAŞ, “Timurid Experimentation”, 283).

52 Ibid., 286.

53 On this work, of which at least 29 manuscript copies survive, see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “The Quest”, 102–105; Şābir IMĀMĪ, “Qışsa-pardāzi dar ‘*Aql u ‘ishq*”, *Adabiyāt-i dāstānī* 101 (Tir 1385 hš/July 2006): 94–100. A critical edition has been published as ‘*Aql u ‘ishq, yā Munāẓarāt-i khams*, ed. Akram Jūdi-Ni‘matī, Tehran: Ahl-i Qalam, 1375 hš/1997. That it was influenced in particular by Suhrawardī’s *Mu‘nis al-‘ushshāq* has been suggested by Nasrollah POURJAVADY (“*Mu‘nis al-‘ushshāq-i Suhrawardī va ta‘ṣīr-i ān dar adabiyāt-i fārsī*”, *Nashr-i dānish* 18/2 (1380 hš/2001): 14–15). For an analysis of Suhrawardī’s romances or allegories see Taqī PŪRNĀMDĀRĪ-YĀN, ‘*Aql-i surkh: Sharḥ u ta‘vīl-i dāstān-hā-yi ramzī-yi Suhrawardī*, Tehran: Intishārāt-i Sukhan, 1390 hš/2011; they are translated in *The Mystical and Visionary Treatises of Shihabuddin Yahya Suhraward*, trans. W. M. Thackston, Jr., London: Octagon Press, 1982.

debates solving many fundamental philosophical problems – including in the first place the ontological rivalry between intellect and love (hence the alternative title). The five debates include: 1) that between the partisans of *‘aql* and the partisans of *‘ishq*; 2) that between the estimative faculty (*vahm*) and *‘aql*; 3) that between *vahm* and the imaginal faculty (*khayāl*); 4) that between hearing (*sam‘*) and sight (*baṣar*); 5) that between lover (*‘āshiq*) and beloved (*ma‘shūq*). In this work, love wins the debate and takes possession of the realm as absolute king of the whole, but appoints intellect or reason its vizier.

Such remains *‘aql*’s role in the later *munāẓara* here under discussion: Sultan Love, world emperor (*jahān-muṭā‘*), dispatches Vizier Reason to study the merits of the two faction’s arguments, together with Commander Intuition (*qahramān-i zawq*), then renders its unitive judgment on the basis of their joint report. Thus love’s empire – the cosmos – must depend on reason, like civilization depends on justice; but for Ibn Turka, as for Davānī after him and Ṭūsī before, the latter two are necessarily ontologically secondary to the former, their sovereign.

Love as Talisman

But how to *weaponize* this ontological primacy of love? How to imperially harness that perpetual bonding, that harmonious correspondence, that marries heaven to earth?

Enter the talisman (Ar. *ṭilasm*, Pers. *ṭilism*). In classifications of the sciences (sg. *taṣnīf al-‘ulūm*), these most popular of occult-scientific devices are routinely defined as follows, from Ibn Sīnā onward:

A form of celestial magic that conjuncts celestial virtues with the virtues of certain terrestrial bodies (*tamzīj-i quvā-yi samāvi bi quvā-yi ba‘ẓi ajrām-i arzī*) to produce a power (*quvvatī*) that gives rise to an unusual action in this world (*mabda‘-i fi‘li gharīb dar in ‘ālam*).⁵⁴

While various methods were employed to achieve this celestial-terrestrial conjunction in the long history of talismanic practice, pre-Islamic and Islamic, by the period here in view most manuals on the subject present the magic square (*wafq al-a‘dād*) as primary engine of a talisman: for only a magic square can mathematically capture, and therefore celestially harness, the names of God, angels, jinn,

⁵⁴ Thus the definition of the illuminationist philosopher-astronomer Quṭb al-Dīn Shīrāzī (d. 1311), essentially reiterating that Ibn Sīnā gives in his *R. fī Aqsām al-‘ulūm al-‘aqliyya* (*Durrat al-tāj: Baksh-i nukhustīn*, ed. Muḥammad Mishkāt, Tehran: Ḥikmat, 1385 hš / 2006, 155–156).

people or things relevant to the operation at hand. The magic square itself, as a discrete science (*‘ilm al-awfāq*), was classed simply as a form of applied arithmetic (*‘ilm al-‘adad*), first of the *quadrivium*, and of no particular occult valence within its own remit (the English term notwithstanding); but with the neopythagorean-occultist renaissance of the turn of the 15th century, the science of magic squares, and by extension the science of talismans with which it had fused, was theoretically and practically subsumed under the rubric of lettrism as new universal science.⁵⁵

That is to say: In the early modern Persianate world, the construction of magic-square-driven talismans was the primary form of high *letter magic*, just as the construction of books of *jafr* was the primary form of high *letter divination*. Less elite or complex forms of both categories of applied lettrism persisted as well, to be sure, more appropriate for daily and local use. But the construction of an *imperial talisman* – that is, a talisman for war, assassination, political advancement or the protection of cities against plague – required a thorough mastery of mathematics, astronomy-astrology and lettrism, and an unswerving commitment to neopythagorean-neoplatonic philosophy. And that philosophy, as we have seen, was in turn predicated on the principles of cosmic love and celestial-terrestrial correspondence.

We may therefore speak, I think, of *imperial talismanic Love*: Fakhr al-Zamānī’s *‘āshiqī* is tantamount to Ghālib Lakhnāvi’s *ṭilism*. For how else could the holy body of Temūr’s scion Akbar – that astrocratic sovereign and self-declared supreme Lord of Conjunction – be theorized as talisman, transforming all of India into a universally harmonious and humorally balanced imperium of love?⁵⁶

⁵⁵ On the classification of talismans in encyclopedias of the sciences see Matthew MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “Powers of One: The Mathematicalization of the Occult Sciences in the High Persianate Tradition”, *Intellectual History of the Islamicate World* 5/1 (2017): 127–199. It should be noted that earlier manuals on magic squares, unlike those produced in the post-Mongol period, do not treat of their occult-scientific applications (my thanks to Bink Hallum for this observation).

⁵⁶ It should be noted that Akbar’s famous doctrine of Universal Harmony (*ṣulḥ-i kull*) is in the first place an alchemical-medical reference (my thanks to Daniel Sheffield for this observation; on its Nuqtavi precedent see his forthcoming “The Lord of the Planetary Court: Cosmic Aspects of Millennial Sovereignty in the Thought of Āzar Kayvān and His Associates”).

The New Brethren of Purity, Ideologues of Empire

Why the sudden burgeoning of lettrism in the early 15th century as a primary mode of political and scientific discourse? Who were the theoreticians of this occult science of empire?

Space does not here permit, of course, a discussion of the philosophical, and political, salience and historical development of the science of letters (*‘ilm al-ḥurūf*), or lettrism, or Ibn Turka’s dealings with members of the Timurid ruling elite, topics I have treated of elsewhere at length.⁵⁷ Suffice it to say that the *Munāẓara-yi bazm u razm* epitomizes the philosophical-imperial project of the New Brethren of Purity, that scholarly network of neopythagorean occultists radiating outward from late Mamluk Cairo northward and eastward to the Ottoman and Timurid realms respectively, and thence to India.⁵⁸ The pivot of this network was Sayyid Ḥusayn Akhlāṭī (d. 1397), Tabrizī Kurdish alchemist-lettrist and personal physician to Sultan Barqūq (r. 1382–1399), and teacher of the greatest occult philosophers of the next generation – including in the first place his *khalīfa* in the Timurid east, Ibn Turka. His *khalīfa* to the Ottoman north, the revolutionary Shaykh Badr al-Dīn (executed 1420), was an associate in turn of ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Bisṭāmī (d. 1454), whose voluminous works on the occult sciences would similarly come to serve as important prop to nascent Ottoman eschatological-imperial ideology.⁵⁹ Al-Bisṭāmī thus stands as Ibn Turka’s Anatolian cognate; but where the former was encyclopedic in his approach, compiling masses of material from hundreds of authorities (most of them ṣūfī), the latter was philosophically rigorously systematizing and synthetic, and cites few authorities apart from Ibn ‘Arabī. Where al-Bisṭāmī’s lettrism is primarily Būnian, that is, focused more on praxis, Ibn Turka’s is Ibn ‘Arabian, focused more on theory; and the latter pointedly reformulated lettrism as a mode of theory and praxis distinct from and supe-

57 For an overview see e.g. Matthew MELVIN-KOUSHKI and James PICKETT, “Mobilizing Magic: Occultism in Central Asia and the Continuity of High Persianate Culture under Russian Rule”, *Studia Islamica* 111/2 (2016): 246–263; MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “The Quest”, *passim*; idem, “Ibn Turka”, *EP* and idem, *The Occult Science of Empire*.

58 On the New Brethren of Purity see FLEISCHER, “Ancient Wisdom”; İhsan FAZLIOĞLU, “İlk Dönem Osmanlı İlim ve Kültür Hayatında İhvanu’s-Safâ ve Abdurrahman Bisṭâmî”, *Dîvân: İlmî Araştırmalar Dergisi* 1/2 (1996): 229–240; BINBAŞ, *Intellectual Networks*, 3–15; MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “The New Brethren of Purity: Ibn Turka and the Renaissance of Neopythagoreanism in the Early Modern Persian Cosmopolis,” in *Companion to the Reception of Pythagoras and Pythagoreanism*, ed. Aurélien Robert, Irene Caiazzo and Constantin Macris, 2 vols., Leiden: Brill, forthcoming 2019.

59 FLEISCHER, “Ancient Wisdom”.

rior to sufism.⁶⁰ His stated project: to establish lettrism, *contra* both Avicennan peripateticism and Suhrawardian illuminationism, as the only philosophically valid form of metaphysics – and the primary basis of Islamic universal empire.

To discern the theoretical core animating the Brethren of Purity network and undergirding its new ideology of empire, it is therefore to Ibn Turka and his Isfahan Circle, including in the first place Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī, we must turn. The centerpiece of our occult philosopher's oeuvre is his *Book of Inquiries* (*K. al-Ma-fāḥiṣ*); completed in 1420 and revised and expanded in 1425, it represents the first *summa* of Islamic neopythagoreanism, and serves as manifesto of the Brethren of Purity network more generally. Therein Ibn Turka attacks the very foundations of Avicennan-Suhrawardian philosophy: he asserts *letter-number* (*ḥarf*), rather than the peripatetics' *being* (*wujūd*) or the illuminationists' *essence* (*māhiyya*) or *light* (*nūr*), to be the proper object of any metaphysics worth the name.⁶¹ The faux-universal concepts of mainstream philosophical speculation notwithstanding, that is, only the letter encompasses all is and is not, all that can and cannot be; it alone is the *coincidentia oppositorum* (*majmaʿ al-aḍḍād, taʿānuq al-aṭrāf*), the intellect's sole vehicle of return to the One. Lettrism is therefore the only truly universal science, a *total neopythagorean-neoplatonic physics-metaphysics* that allows for the analysis, and manipulation, of celestial and physical entities in equal measure – especially mathematically.

Ibn Turka develops the ramifications of his new lettrist physics-metaphysics across his oeuvre as a whole, the majority of which is devoted to this project, including in four works (three Persian and one Arabic) dedicated to four members of the Timurid ruling elite respectively. In chronological order, they are:

- 1) *On the Letters* (*R. Ḥurūf*): Written in 1414 in Shiraz for Iskandar Sulṭān b. ʿUmar Shaykh b. Temür (r. 1409–1414), Ibn Turka's first Timurid patron, this is his first treatise on lettrism proper; it serves as preview of the *Book of Inquiries* itself, almost certainly begun for the benefit of the same patron.⁶² (Ibn Turka likewise completed his landmark and lettrist *Sharḥ Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam* in 1411 while attached to Iskandar Sulṭān's court.) It is of the utmost significance for our purposes here that Iskandar Sulṭān seized precisely on Ibn Turkian lettrism, together with astronomy-astrology, to fashion himself the first Timurid

⁶⁰ As, e.g., in his important treatise *On the Splitting of the Moon and the Last Hour*, also completed in 1426; for an analysis see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "The Quest", ch. 6, and for a translation see *ibid.*, 454–462.

⁶¹ On his *tashkik al-ḥarf* doctrine see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "Of Islamic Grammatology", 60–62.

⁶² An edition and translation of this treatise is provided in MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "The Quest", 463–489.

saint-philosopher-king, establishing a culturally brilliant court in Shiraz and then Isfahan to that end.⁶³ And while his reign in western Iran was brief and abortive – he was defeated and blinded by his uncle Shāhrukh b. Temür in the same year and executed in 1415 –, it was nevertheless his occult-scientific model of Timurid sovereignty, not Shāhrukh's comparatively conservative Sunnī-sultanic one, that ultimately prevailed; in the expansive 16th century, with the approach of the Islamic millennium (1592 CE), it emerged as the default mode of Islamic imperialism throughout the Persianate world.⁶⁴

- 2) *Query of Kings* (*R. Su'l al-mulūk*): Ibn Turka's relationship with Shāhrukh, ultimate victor in the succession struggle that followed Temür's death, was less successful; his attempt to persuade the Timurid ruler of the imperial usefulness of lettrism seems, like Iskandar Sulṭān's reign, to have been abortive.⁶⁵ This attempt took the form of this highly accessible introductory treatise; written for Shāhrukh in early 1426 at Bāysunghur's instance, it treats of

⁶³ His expansive, occult-scientific patronage program aside, the legitimacy of this ambitious Timurid ruler's claim to being a spiritually perfected philosopher-scientist in his own right is best seen in the preface (*dībācha*) he wrote for a comprehensive Persian manual of mathematical astronomy (*'ilm-i hay'at*), *Jāmi'-i sulṭānī*, possibly his own work as well. Here he provides an overview of his personal intellectual and spiritual development as proof of his status as Perfect Man (*insān-i kāmīl*) and universal ruler, emperor of realms both seen and unseen. In particular, he claims to have mastered all the traditional and rational sciences, including theology, philosophy and sufism, but finally declares astronomy-astrology (*'ilm-i nujūm*) to be of all sciences the most useful to kings – with the exception of lettrism, the sole universal science in its status as chiefest branch of *'ilm-i tawhīd* (Matthew MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "Timurid-Mughal Philosopher-Kings as Sultan-Scientists", in *Rulers as Authors in the Islamic World: Knowledge, Authority and Legitimacy*, ed. Maribel Fierro, Sonja Brentjes and Tilman Seidensticker, Leiden: Brill, forthcoming 2020; see also BINBAŞ, *Intellectual Networks*, 89–96, 272–74).

⁶⁴ MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "Early Modern Islamic Empire: New Forms of Religiopolitical Legitimacy", in *The Wiley-Blackwell History of Islam*, ed. Armando Salvatore et al., Hoboken: Wiley-Blackwell, 2017, 353–357; BINBAŞ, *Intellectual Networks*. On Ilkhanid precedent see Jonathan Z. BRACK, "Mediating Sacred Kingship: Conversion and Sovereignty in Mongol Iran", Ph.D. dissertation, University of Michigan, 2016. As BINBAŞ elsewhere notes ("Timurid Experimentation", 300): "If the rise of absolutist politics is one of the benchmarks for early modernity, in 816/1412 Shāhrukh was the last medieval Islamic ruler, and Mirzā Iskandar was the first early modern absolutist sovereign, albeit an unsuccessful one."

⁶⁵ This was due in the first place to the status of the anarchic Hurūfiyya as a thorn in Shāhrukh's – and by extension Ibn Turka's – side; as the latter bemoaned in his second apology, their extremist šūfī lettrist doctrine, to be carefully distinguished from that of the Brethren, had sullied the reputation of true lettrists and given leverage to their political enemies against them (MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "The Quest", 417–418, 430–433; on early Hurufi doctrine see Orkhan MIR-KASIMOV, *Words of Power: Hurufi Teachings between Shi'ism and Sufism in Medieval Islam: The Original Doctrine of Faql Allāh Astarābādī*, London: I. B. Tauris, 2015).

both theoretical and applied (i.e., alchemical and talismanic) lettrism. Most notably, the *Su'l al-mulūk* ends with a lettrist prognostication as to the duration of the Timurid – that is to say, Shahrukhid – state, whereby Ibn Turka acclaims Shāhrukh the fated ruler of the 9th Islamic century as a whole.⁶⁶

- 3) *Explication of the Basmala (Sharḥ al-basmala)*: Historians of science have hailed the Samarkand Observatory and Madrasa complex of Ulugh Beg b. Shāhrukh (r. 1409–1449) as the foremost Western scientific institution of the 15th century, site of the epochal *mathematization of astronomy* – the immediate intellectual precedent for Copernicus, Kepler and Newton. What they have flatly ignored to date, however, is the intellectual, social and political context in which this mathematical revolution took place. That context is precisely the contemporary renaissance of lettrist neopythagoreanism, which posits the cosmos as a mathematical matrix.⁶⁷ Most notably, the first director of the observatory, Qāzizāda Rūmī (d. 1432), was a friend and associate to Ibn Turka from childhood, and the two maintained a warm correspondence through the height of their careers. That the Ottoman-Timurid astronomer-mathematician was perfectly conversant with his colleague's new lettrist physics-metaphysics is suggested by an extant letter from the former thanking the latter for sending a copy of his *Sharḥ al-basmala*, a philosophically dense and book-length Arabic treatment of the theme, likewise completed in early 1426;⁶⁸ that Ibn Turka also dedicated the work to Ulugh Beg – here *explicitly styled a philosopher-king* – suggests that the latter was equally conversant. (It is not an accident in this context that the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* was completed the same year, 1420, that construction of the observatory was begun; and Yazdī himself worked for a time there.⁶⁹) Ibn Turka therein exclaims of his intended sultan-scientist (*al-sultān al-faylasūf*) patron: 'Long have I held out hope for just such a time – and that time is yours!'⁷⁰
- 4) *Debate of Feast and Fight*: The fourth and last in this series of treatises. That it, like the *Query of Kings*, was written at the request of Bāysunghur suggests

⁶⁶ This he does through a simple analysis of Shāhrukh's name, which converts to *shāh-i rukh*, i.e., *shāh-i RKh*, or shah of 800. See MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "The Quest", 311–314; an edition of this treatise is provided in *ibid.*, 507–527.

⁶⁷ MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "Powers of One".

⁶⁸ On this work see *ibid.*, 111–112.

⁶⁹ BINBAŞ, *Intellectual Networks*, 65.

⁷⁰ MS Majlis 10196, f. 332b: *wa-kuntu dhakhartu āmāl-i li-waqtin, wa-kāna l-waqtu waqta-ka*. See MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "Powers of One"; İhsan FAZLIOĞLU, "The Samarqand Mathematical-Astronomical School: A Basis for Ottoman Philosophy and Science", *Journal for the History of Arabic Science* 14 (2008): 41.

that Ibn Turka's intended audience here was also Shāhrukh. And while that conservative ruler – unlike his nephew and rival Iskandar Sulṭān and his own sons Ulugh Beg and Bāysunghur – seems not to have been receptive,⁷¹ it is here that Ibn Turka formulates his lettrist theory of Islamic universalist imperialism most succinctly and explicitly. Moreover, that Bāysunghur was an accomplished calligrapher is highly relevant in this connection; I have elsewhere argued that Ibn Turka's lettrist theory, valorizing written letter-number as a form of light and fullest manifestation of the One, undergirds the explosion of Persianate book culture, and by extension Persianate visual culture (including both calligraphy and book painting), during the 15th and 16th centuries. His could not but be an attractive philosophy to such masters of the pen – and sword – as the Timurid prince.⁷²

For all that the Timurid model of philosopher-kingship is based on Ilkhanid precedent,⁷³ then, the imperial-ideological pairing of lettrism with astronomy-astrology accomplished by Ibn Turka, his colleagues and his patrons is unprecedented and utterly distinctive; a *dual astrological-lettrist platform* accordingly became the chiefest means of signaling Timurid sovereignty through at least the 17th century. As a case in point: the Mughal – i.e., Indo-Timurid – emperor Shāhjahān (r. 1628–1657), grandson of the millennial sovereign Akbar, commissioned a star table (*zīj*) to celebrate his accession as Second Lord of Conjunction (*ṣāhib-qirān-i ṣānī*), the *Zīj-i Shāhjahānī*. Formally an updated and corrected version of Ulugh Beg's definitive *Zīj-i jadīd-i sulṭānī*, its introduction, for the first time in the history of the genre, makes explicit what is merely implicit in its 15th-century source: the proper scientific context for the mathematical study of the heavens – and hence dominion over the earth – is precisely *lettrism*.⁷⁴

71 On Ibn Turka's political difficulties under Shāhrukh and three inquisitions in Herat see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "The Quest", 58–68. The *Munāzara-yi bazm u razm*, written in Herat, would seem to have been composed just ahead of or during his second trial; he wrote his first apology (*Nafsat al-maṣdūr-i avval*) and creedal statement (*R. I'tiqādāt*) for Shāhrukh in the same city in the same year.

72 MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "Of Islamic Grammatology". On Bāysunghur as book artist and patron of book artists, as well as warrior and hunter, see David ROXBURGH, "Baysunghur's Library: Questions Related to Its Chronology and Production", *Journal of Social Affairs* 18 (2001): 11–41; on his military campaigns see Beatrice F. MANZ, *Power, Politics and Religion in Timurid Iran*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007, *passim*.

73 BRACK, "Mediating Sacred Kingship".

74 MOIN, *The Millennial Sovereign*, 23–24; MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "Early Modern Islamicate Empire"; idem, "Timurid-Mughal Philosopher-Kings."

This peculiarly Timurid dual astrological-lettrist platform, first embraced by Iskandar Sulṭān and latterly by Shāhjahān, is equally explicit in the *Ẓafarnāma* of Sharaf al-Dīn Yazdī, Ibn Turka's student, friend and fellow disciple of Akhlāfī. Completed in 1428–1429 – i.e., precisely 200 years before the *Zīj-i Shāhjahānī* –, the *Book of Conquest* is the most influential of the histories of Temūr: for unlike earlier offerings in this vein, it provides a robust theoretical basis for styling Temūr the supreme Lord of Conjunction. It is also stylistically gorgeous, and was much imitated by persophone historians thereafter. In a number of key passages Yazdī offers strictly lettrist proofs for the inevitability of Temūr's glorious conquests;⁷⁵ but one in particular epitomizes the approach of the Brethren as a whole. Most notably, and applying the basic thesis of the *Munāẓara-yi bazm u razm* (completed only two years prior), here Yazdī styles Temūr a historical manifestation of the *coincidentia oppositorum* on the basis of astrological and lettrist proofs. I translate it in full below for its importance to our theme here:

The manifestation of [the Lord of Conjunction's glorious rule] first dawned from the horizon of conquest and victory, inaugurating an era of abundant joy and celebration in which the tongue of laudation does indite:

What a dream whose interpretation is you!
What a verse whose exegesis is you!

Yea, the splendor of his auspicious brow shone forth like the sun. For the instant the sun enters the heaven that is the throne of sovereignty over the seven climes, the world is illumined: the significance of his auspicious rise like the bright and revealing dawn itself, quickly banishing the night that is the disorder of the world, is thus that the ascent of his fortune is the dawning of a day gladder than the New Year festival itself.

The verification (*taḥqīq*) of this statement is as follows: Establishing the bases of rule and erecting the walls of caliphate, the blessed being of that holy eminence – Lord of Conjunction, Last Emperor in History (*ākhir al-zamān*) – stands as the firm and unshakable foundation of the fortune of his glorious house; his horoscope must therefore reflect the extreme firmness of that foundation. Yet the affairs of the world are forever subject to change and revolution (*inqilāb*). According to the manifest wisdom of the dictum *He directs the affair from heaven to earth* (Q 32:5), then, which indicates the fact that in the workshop of creation the embroidering of satin – i.e., events in the [sublunary] realm of generation and corruption – is a process that requires its tying to what is above, it is necessary that

⁷⁵ See e.g. *Ẓafarnāma*, ed. Sa'īd M. M. Šādiq and 'Abd al-Ḥusayn Navā'i, 2 vols., Tehran: Kitāb-khāna-yi mūza u markaz-i asnād-i majlis-i shūrā-yi islāmī, 1387 hš/2008, 1/404–405, 2/1146, 1295. These passages are translated in Matthew MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "In Defense of Geomancy: Šaraf al-Dīn Yazdī Rebutts Ibn Ḥaldūn's Critique of the Occult Sciences", in *Islamicate Occultism: New Perspectives*, ed. Matthew Melvin-Koushki and Noah Gardiner, special double issue of *Arabica* 64/3–4 (2017): 346–403, 388–391.

his august Ascendant occupy a sign of the zodiac that is characterized by a firmness that yet does not negate revolution. Now the only sign to have this [dual] quality is Capricorn: it is firm in its elemental association with earth and its celestial-planetary association with Saturn; at the same time, it is among the cardinal (*munqalib*) signs. [His Ascendant being in Capricorn], in the earthy house of Saturn, therefore simultaneously represents absolute stability and total revolution.

An indication more powerful as to stability and perdurance cannot possibly be imagined. According to verifiers (*ahl-i taḥqīq*), moreover, it is an established principle that the ultimate perfection of a given quality can only be achieved through union with its opposite (*bā zidd-i khūd mu'āniq*), as any consideration of the nature of the Most Beautiful Names (be they exalted) will make evident: *He is the First and the Last, the Manifest and the Occult; He has knowledge of everything* (Q 57:3).

On the basis of these subtle and occult (*gharīb*) premises, then, it should be clear that when firmness and durability are desired the most appropriate zodiacal sign for governing events in engendered existence is Capricorn. And indeed, the sweet scent of the verity of this argument may be inhaled from the truth-gardens that bloom with the secrets of the revealed isolated quranic letters (*muqaṭṭa'āt-i ḥurūf-i munzala-yi qur'ānī*).

[Analysis of Temür's horoscope]

The judgments of the seven stars promise plainly:
they will unlock the world.⁷⁶

Thus does Yazdī simultaneously apply the three primary doctrines of the *ahl-i taḥqīq* (i.e., the Brethren) to the historical persona of Temür: the *coincidentia oppositorum*, i.e., letter-number; the influence of celestial bodies on terrestrial events; and the status of the quranic *muqaṭṭa'āt* as keys to the cosmos.⁷⁷ His invocation of the quranic dictum *He is the First and the Last, the Manifest and the Occult* is likewise pregnant: it is the Brethren's primary motto and rallying call, constantly cited by all members of the network to signal their membership therein.

That this lettrist-astrological ideology of Islamic empire represents a deliberate departure from neopythagorean-occultist precedent cannot be overemphasized. Yazdī, indeed, following Ibn Turka, here invents a new form of *imperial neopythagorean historiography*.⁷⁸ The original Brethren of 10th-century Abbasid

⁷⁶ Ibid., 1/236–238.

⁷⁷ See BINBAŞ, *Intellectual Networks*, 100.

⁷⁸ On the subsequent ottomanization of Yazdī's brand of historiography see Matthew MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "Toward a Neopythagorean Historiography: Kemālpaşazāde's (d. 1534) Lettrist Call for the Conquest of Cairo and the Development of Ottoman Occult-Scientific Imperialism", in *Islam-icate Occult Sciences in Theory and Practice*, ed. Liana Saif, Francesca Leoni, Matthew Melvin-Koushki and Farouk Yahya, Leiden: Brill, forthcoming 2020.

Iraq were neither lettrists nor imperialist ideologues – to the contrary, they worked in strict anonymity, and left lettrism to the *şūfis*;⁷⁹ and even the great theologian-occultist Fakhr al-Dīn Rāzī (d. 1210) associated magic with *tyranny* in his seminal grimoire, *al-Sirr al-maktūm*.⁸⁰ For our 15th-century Brethren, however, it is (letter) magic that precisely *guarantees imperial righteousness*.

Parenthetical mention should here be made of another *bazm u razm*, an important Persian chronicle written, some 20 years before Ibn Turka's similarly titled work, by 'Azīz b. Ardashīr Astarābādī Baghdādī (d. ca. 1399) for Qāzī Burhān al-Dīn Aḥmad Oghullarī (r. 1391–1398), sultan of Sivas.⁸¹ Significantly, in the ornate prosimetric introduction the historian fashions his scholar-turned-ruler patron as a true philosopher-king: judge (*dāvar*), warrior (*shajā*), patron (*karīm*), learned (*kāmil*), eloquent (*faṣīḥ*)⁸² – and hence, naturally, a Lord of Conjunction (*sulṭān-i 'ādil u ṣāḥib-qirān-i kāmil*).⁸³ A detailed discussion of his horoscope accordingly follows, wherein the ruler is even styled somewhat of a saint.⁸⁴

⁷⁹ A move in the imperial-occultist direction so roundly embraced by their 15th-century heirs may be seen, however, in the long version of the Brethren's concluding epistle on magic, which advocates for the use of magic and divination in imperial administration and as support for a form of sacral kingship (Liana SAIF, "Ikhwān al-Ṣafā's Religious Reform and Magic: Beyond the Isma'ili Hypothesis", *Journal of Islamic Studies* 29 (2018): 1–36). As Pierre LORY has concluded, referring to the high magic that is central to their project ("La magie chez les Ikhwān al-Ṣafā", *Bulletin d'Études Orientales* 44 (1992): 149): "C'est elle qui, fondée sur une conception précise des mondes angéliques, explique le pouvoir des prophètes, des rois, des saints; c'est elle qui permet éventuellement au philosophe d'avoir accès à la *siyāsa*, c'est-à-dire de participer au gouvernement de Dieu sur terre". For it is by means of magic and talismans alone, assert the Ikhwān, that 'subjects are joined to [the rank of] kings and kings to that of angels' (*tulḥaḡu bi-hi l-ra'yyatu bi-l-mulūki wa-l-mulūku bi-l-malā'ika*) (*Epistles of the Brethren of Purity: On Magic I: An Arabic Critical Edition and English Translation of EPISTLE 52a*, ed. and trans. Godefroid de Callataj and Bruno Halflants, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011, trans. p. 95, ed. p. 16). Nevertheless, this general theory is nowhere deployed in the *Rasā'il* in support of an unequivocally *Fatimid* (much less *Abbasid*) brand of saint-philosopher-kingship – this in rather sharp contrast to the specifically *Timurid* imperial platform developed by Ibn Turka and Yazdī for their royal patrons, or the status of al-Bisṭāmī's works as a primary prop to Ottoman eschatological imperialism.

⁸⁰ My thanks to Michael Noble for the latter observation; see his forthcoming work on the *Sirr*.

⁸¹ *Bazm u razm*, ed. Mehmet Fuat Köprülü, Istanbul: Evkaf Matbaası, 1928. On this work and its patron see Ali KARJOO-RAVARY, "Becoming a 'King of Islam': The Imperial Project of Qadi Burhan al-Din of Sivas (1345–1398 CE)", Ph.D. dissertation, University of Pennsylvania, 2018.

⁸² *Ibid.*, 8–10.

⁸³ *Ibid.*, 46, 47, 52.

⁸⁴ *Ibid.*, 47–52. Ibn Ardashīr resolves the disagreement between ancient astrologers, who cast horoscopes according to moment of conception, and modern, who do so according to moment of birth, by employing both methods. Using the second, he cites the conjunction of Saturn and Jupiter (*qirān-i 'ilvīyayn*) in Aquarius in house four, with both making a trine aspect to the As-

Thus while the titular *bazm u razm* is not explicitly developed as a literary theme or otherwise theorized – and certainly not recast in lettrist terms –, it is notable that Ibn Ardashīr too associates it with saint-philosopher-kingship, and that he, like Yazdī after him (though more generically), relies on astrological and numerical proofs to this end.⁸⁵

This, then, is the sociopolitical context in which Ibn Turka – quite successfully, if more so posthumously – theorized Timurid philosopher-kingship in his *Debate of Feast and Fight* as the historical-political incarnation of the *coincidentia oppositorum*, of the divine names the Manifest and the Occult, of Emperor Love. This theory alone was the basis for Iskandar Sulṭān's absolutist claim to combine temporal and spiritual authority in his theosized person; for lettrism, that saint-philosopher-king asserted, is precisely the supreme '*ilm al-tawḥīd*, 'the science of making-one,' and hence the basis for any Islamic henological-universalist imperialism.⁸⁶ Ibn Turka's hopes that this model would be realized were dashed by Iskandar Sulṭān's defeat and execution, then stymied by Shāhrukh's conservatism, but partially revived by Bāysunghur's patronage and Ulugh Beg's emergence as sultan-scientist; and Shāhjahān's updated Timurid-Mughal *zīj* of two centuries later commemorates the ultimate realization of those hopes. To divorce history of science from history of empire in the early modern Persianate context is therefore to cripple the explanatory power of both.

Hybrid Mamluk-Timurid Arabo-Persian Literary-Imperial Culture: Ibn Turka in Cairo

The same principle applies to "postclassical" Arabo-Persian literary history: form cannot be divorced from content – and certainly never when the penmen in question are *lettrists*. It is no accident that the greatest scientists of letters of the first half of the 15th century were also among its greatest prose stylists, including in the first place al-Bisṭāmī in Arabic and Ibn Turka and Yazdī in Persian.⁸⁷ The literary

endant in Libra, as proof of his patron's *ṣāḥib-qirān*-hood, and indicative of political greatness (ibid., 52).

⁸⁵ It may be significant in this connection that Ibn Ardashīr moved to Cairo in 1399 after the death of Qāzī Burhān al-Dīn, and shortly before his own – precisely when Ibn Turka and Yazdī were in the same city.

⁸⁶ See n. 63 above.

⁸⁷ Al-Bisṭāmī himself produced a manual of ornate epistolary prose style, *K. Manāḥij al-tawassul fī mabāḥij al-tarassul* (Constantinople, 1299/1882, 89–160; printed with al-Ṣafādī, *K. Janān*

historian and Pahlavi poet-laureate (*malik al-shu'arā*) Muḥammad-Taqī BAHĀR (d. 1951) even styles Ibn Turka *the* greatest Persian prose stylist of the 15th century as a whole, and the first Persian writer to use an ornate literary (*adabī*) style for philosophical-scientific (*'ilmī*) subjects.⁸⁸ (BAHĀR's admiration for our lettrist's style is all the more remarkable given his dismissal of ornate Safavid-era prose as sterile and empty of meaning.⁸⁹) The *Munāẓara-yi bazm u razm*, of course, epitomizes Ibn Turka's signature *adabī-'ilmī* approach to riddling the text that is the cosmos;⁹⁰ it must therefore not be simply mined for its theoretical data or ideological program (as I have done above), but also savored as the ornate literary work it is. For the fact of its ornateness is equally theoretically and historically significant in this context: theoretically, because it substantiates and performs the author's valorization of textuality, not orality, as sole vehicle of the *philosophia perennis*;⁹¹ and historically, because it testifies to the formation of a hybrid *Mamluk-Timurid Arabo-Persian* literary culture – with Ibn Turka's own oeuvre as a primary vector.

Our author was transformed into both a lettrist and a litterateur in Mamluk Cairo, the most potent cultural alembic – I use the term advisedly – of the late 14th-century Islamic world.⁹² There lettrism itself had been *sanctified*, in the

al-jinās fī 'ilm al-badī', 1–87), as did that other great Timurid lettrist and literary stylist Kāshifi (his *Makhzan al-inshā'* remains unpublished).

88 *Sabk-shināsī, yā Tārīkh-i taṭavvur-i naṣr-i fārsī*, 3 vols. (Tehran: Zavvār, 1381 hš/2002), 3/223–234, 352.

89 *Ibid.*, 3/293–295. Ibn Turka's status as teacher to Kātibi Turshīzī (d. 1436), later accounted the foremost poet of the Shahrukhid period (and author of several debate poems), is likewise significant in this context. Kātibi's *Divān* opens with four poems in eulogy of his teacher, one of which ends by explicitly hailing him the leader of the Brethren (see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "The Quest", 53–55):

The world exchanges the dark of night for the light of morning
like ignorance is transformed to knowledge at the breath of my lord (*khwāja*),
Khwāja Ṣā'in al-Duval wa-l-Dīn, succorer of the Folk of Purity (*mu'in-i ahl-i ṣafā*),
the point of whose pen is the pivot on which the cosmos turns.

90 I use the participle advisedly; the same ethos is likewise epitomized by Yazdī's reformulation of the *mu'ammā* (logograph, riddle), quintessentially ornate, as an important skill in the lettrist's technical repertoire – an immediate, poetic means of analyzing a person's name in order to discern their character, perhaps even their fate (MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "The Quest", 379–389; BINBAŞ, *Intellectual Networks*, 48, 81–89). On the confluence of lettrism and literary ornateness more generally see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "Of Islamic Grammatology", 78–79, 100 n. 198.

91 On Ibn Turka's unprecedented valorization of written language over spoken see *ibid.*

92 On Cairo's new status as the "political and cultural epicenter of the Muslim world" see ELIAS MUHANNA, "Encyclopædism in the Mamlūk Period: The Composition of Shihāb al-Dīn al-Nuwayrī's (d. 1333) *Nihāyat al-Arab fī Funūn al-Adab*", Ph.D. dissertation, Harvard University, 2012, 44–45; and his *The World in a Book: al-Nuwayrī and the Islamic Encyclopedic Tradition*,

13th century, as the Ibn ‘Arabian-Būnian science of the saints (*‘ilm al-awliyā’*) *par excellence*; in the 14th it was then *de-esotericized* and *adabized* through its incorporation into the Mamluk literary-political mainstream; and by the turn of the 15th century it was *neopythagoreanized* by the occultists who would form the Brethren.⁹³ Ibn Turka’s mentor Akhlāṭī, as noted, had been summoned to Cairo to serve as personal physician to Sultan Barqūq; under his influence the Mamluk ruler seems to have developed a keen interest in the occult sciences, as his personal library and choice of courtiers, including Ibn Turka himself, suggest.⁹⁴ Was Barqūq then the first Mamluk sultan to aspire to occult-philosopher-kingship – and so an inspiration for Timurid rivals?

Likely so.⁹⁵ As that may be, the fact remains that Ibn Turka’s first major work, the Persian *Sharḥ-i Naẓm al-durar*, closely tracks high Mamluk Arabic literary culture; it effectively timuridizes the new hybrid Mamluk *anthology-as-commentary* genre, pioneered by Ibn Nubāta (d. 1366) and his student al-Ṣafadī (d. 1363) in particular, both of whom also authored seminal sword vs. pen debates. Completed in 1404 (i.e., toward the end of Ibn Turka’s residence in Cairo), this ornate work is formally a commentary on that favorite teaching text of the Ibn ‘Arabī school tradition, Ibn al-Fāriḍ’s (d. 1235) *al-Tā’iyya al-kubrā*. But it is the first such commentary to effectively *re-poeticize* that tradition. By bringing each line of the poem into conjunction with several Persian or Arabic lines of verse, both contemporary and classical, it welds together the two bodies of literature into a single unbroken tradition; this maneuver had the effect of transferring the canonicity of the classical Arabic corpus to the not-yet-classical Persian poets such as Ḥāfiẓ (d. ca. 1390), Ibn Turka’s earlier contemporary, while simultaneously integrating

Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2018. As for its function as alembic: the alchemist-lettrist Akhlāṭī aside, Cairo was also home to the greatest Arabic alchemist after Jābir b. Ḥayyān himself, Aydemir al-Jildakī, who flourished there for much of the 14th century; all Arabic alchemy thereafter is thus Jildakian (on this “Paracelsus of Islam” – still otherwise astonishingly unstudied – see Nicholas HARRIS, “Better Religion through Chemistry: Aydemir al-Jildakī and Alchemy under the Mamluks,” Ph.D. dissertation, University of Pennsylvania, forthcoming).

⁹³ On these processes see Noah D. GARDINER, “Esotericism in a Manuscript Culture: Aḥmad al-Būnī and His Readers through the Mamlūk Period”, Ph.D. dissertation, University of Michigan, 2014; MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “Powers of One”; idem, “The New Brethren.”

⁹⁴ Ibn Turka’s presence at Barqūq’s court is confirmed by an episode the latter relates in his second apology – written for Bāysunghur – wherein the ruler presses him for his (poor) opinion of another scholar, the Damascene traditionist Ibn al-Jazarī (d. 1429); see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “The Quest”, 47, 61.

⁹⁵ On Barqūq’s lettrist interests see Noah GARDINER, “The Occultist Encyclopedism of ‘Abd al-Raḥmān al-Biṣṭāmī”, *Mamlūk Studies Review* 20 (2017): 3–38, as well as his paper in development “al-Malik al-Zāhir Barqūq as Millennial Sovereign?”

Ibn ‘Arabian theory as the default interpretive frame for Mamluk-Timurid Arabo-Persian poetic culture.⁹⁶

It was also in Cairo that our Isfahani lettrist made his first formal foray into the *munāẓara* genre: the abovementioned ‘*Aql u ‘ishq*, whose imperial scenario is reiterated and recast, as we have seen, in the *Munāẓara-yi bazm u razm*, composed in Herat some 21 years later. The latter work, however, unlike the former, is strictly unprecedented in Persian or Arabic letters; it is not only the first (and perhaps last) *lettrist* sword vs. pen *munāẓara* in the tradition, but also the first to hybridize that genre with the Avicennan-Suhravardian philosophical romance.

Such a hybridizing, synthesizing sensibility precisely defines high Mamluk literary culture; the oeuvre of Ibn Turka – whose Arabic prose was equally stylistically impeccable, and who was in fact a Turk⁹⁷ – must therefore be considered an integral part of that culture. More: he was its first exponent to make the doctrine of the *coincidentia oppositorum* the explicit philosophical basis for its rampant, encyclopedic, literary hybridity, thereby ratifying this ethos and entrenching it as early modern Islamicate writerly-cultural default.⁹⁸ But the late Mamluk literary scene has been far better studied to date than the contemporary early Timurid, and always in strict isolation from the latter. This has had the effect of disappearing precisely the *literary* significance of lettrists like Ibn Turka – who himself performed on the page the classic role of arbiter and *coincidentia oppositorum*, whose very oeuvre constitutes a dual Arabic vs. Persian-Mamluk vs. Timurid *munāẓara* that concludes by marrying the two twains.

The moral of the story: To do justice to the totalizing, hybridizing, universalizing impulse that defines the high literary cultures and the imperial ideologies of the post-Mongol era in equal measure, cultural historians must more rigorously eschew the colonialist-nationalist approach upon which orientalism as an academic discipline is founded, whose *divide et impera* strategy, brutally effective, severs the basic ligamentations of globalizing Islamicate culture. Thereby Arab and Persian, Persian and Turk, Turk and Mongol, litterateur and lettrist are sun-

⁹⁶ MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “The Quest” 379–416. It should be noted in this connection that Ibn Turka is one of the first Persian authors to regularly quote Ḥāfiẓ – which Shīrāzī poet was, of course, a ringleader of the School of Love (*māẓhab-i ‘ishq*), and whose *Divān* would become “the most widely-copied, widely-circulated, widely-read, widely-memorized, widely-recited, widely-invoked, and widely-proverbalized book of poetry in Islamic history” (Shahab AHMED, *What Is Islam? The Importance of Being Islamic*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2015, 32–46).

⁹⁷ The name Turka, or ‘little Turk’ (Littleturk), is in reference to the family’s Turkic origins; an ancestor is said to have emigrated from Khujand in the Farghana valley to Isfahan in the Khwarazmshahid-Seljuq period (MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “The Quest”, 38).

⁹⁸ Again, on this theme see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “Of Islamic Grammatology”.

dered one from the other and made to stumble (backwards, of course) separately into modernity.

Just such a violent line in the sand still largely quarantines the study of the *munāẓara* as genre into neat Arabic and Persian nation-states. Thus while several scholars have penetratingly analyzed the *munāẓaras* penned by Ibn Nubāta, al-Ṣafadī and al-Qalqashandī (d. 1418) – the immediate literary context for Ibn Turka’s own –, the present article is the first to do the same for the latter. As the example of our letrist’s *munāẓara* conclusively shows, however, to adequately treat of late Mamluk literary practice in its own right and this 14th–15th-century moment more generally, we must widen our analytical aperture to include the Timurid and Ottoman realms as well, where Mamluk culture, itself a confluence of Abbasid, Ayyubid and Seljuq cultures, was absorbed and transformed. For by the turn of the 15th century Cairo had become the occult-scientific capital of the *Persian* cosmopolis, primary entrepot for the transmission of Ibn ‘Arabi-an-Būnian lettrism eastward and northward. We should therefore expect to find telltale markers of this cultural seachange even in (ostensibly) strictly literary works – especially those produced by Barqūqian litterateurs.

Al-Qalqashandī’s (Pro-Letrlist) Sword vs. Pen Debate

Suggestively enough, al-Qalqashandī – whom Ibn Turka doubtlessly met – similarly *resolves the opposites*. This he did, for the benefit of the Manifest King (*al-malik al-zāhir*) Barqūq, in a sword vs. pen debate written in eulogy of Barqūq’s beloved *dawādār*, Abū Yazīd al-Zāhirī (like Bāysunghur a skilled calligrapher), on the occasion of the latter’s appointment in 1397 (the year of Akhlāṭī’s death). His primary models are the Arabic *munāẓaras* in this vein by Ibn Burd, Ibn Nubāta, Ibn al-Wardī (d. 1349) and al-Ṣafadī.⁹⁹ In his study of this cluster of texts, Geert Jan VAN GELDER concludes that they “display variation rather than progression,” each trying to outdo the other but not fundamentally changing the established rules of the genre.¹⁰⁰ (Indeed, all four end as a draw between sword and pen, and in Ibn al-Wardī’s, al-Ṣafadī’s and al-Qalqashandī’s versions it is the pen that proposes

⁹⁹ VAN GELDER, “The Conceit”, 358: “Ibn Nubāta tried to outdo Ibn al-Wardī, the Egyptian al-Qalqashandī ... took his inspiration mainly from Ibn Burd’s debate, even though it is not mentioned ... However, the texts of Ibn al-Wardī and Ibn Nubāta have left their traces, too”.

¹⁰⁰ Ibid., 359.

conciliation.¹⁰¹) But such a conclusion abstracts these Mamluk *munāẓaras* from their differing sociopolitical contexts. The relationship between swordmen and penmen hardly remained static; and the cultural context in which al-Qalqashandī was writing was scene to an occultist renaissance, due not least to the patronage of Barqūq himself. As Adrian GULLY notes in his complementary study on the same texts: “[It is not accidental] that al-Qalqashandī wrote what appears to be a definitive version of the sword vs. pen literary contest and concluded it with a true conciliation of peace between the two instruments that is not present in any of the other prose texts on this subject”.¹⁰² I entirely agree: this move is deliberate. But why did he make it? How does his *munāẓara* simultaneously adhere to and break from literary precedent to reflect a specifically Barqūqian ethos?

By the simple expedient of introducing an unmistakably technical term in his valorization of the debate’s arbiter and dedicatee, Dawadar Abū Yazīd: he pointedly hails him as *al-jāmi‘ bayn al-aqdād*.¹⁰³ This, of course, is a standard term for the *coincidentia oppositorum*. The un/precedentedness of al-Qalqashandī’s offering is therefore illegible absent its patently *lettrist* sociopolitical context; for it is likewise no accident that this Mamluk penman, together with fellow encyclopedist al-Nuwayrī (d. 1333), contributed to the epochal adabization of Būnian letter magic.¹⁰⁴ This is not to suggest, however, that he makes the term’s new *lettrist* context explicit, or marries *munāẓara* to philosophical romance; only his fellow Cairene litterateur Ibn Turka does that. Their two *munāẓaras* must therefore be read in conjunction lest pregnant nuance – and ornate literary cultures are nothing if not mad for nuance – be missed.

As control for the study of Ibn Turka’s *Debate of Feast and Fight*, I therefore translate below the concluding section of al-Qalqashandī’s *Mufākharat al-sayf wa-l-qalam*, preserved in his monumental *Ṣubḥ al-a‘shā fī šinā‘at al-inshā’*:

The pen then purposed to offer a rejoinder and continue the dispute, but was overcome by its innate delicacy of feeling and bent toward beauty and compliance; it preferred the wisdom (*ḥilm*) of reconciliation to the folly (*jahl*) of conflict. Pure of heart and supple of tongue, pen turned to sword and said: “Our dispute has dragged on, and arguments and counterarguments have multiplied! Yet we are similar in rank and have each won an equal portion of excellence; we are brothers in honor and partners in glory. Neither one of us is

101 GULLY, “The Sword and the Pen”, 413–414.

102 Ibid., 410.

103 AS VAN GELDER notes (ibid.): “The title of his office, ‘keeper of the inkwell’, is an appropriate indication of the fact that the separation between civil and military power was by no means absolute. The *dawādār*, one of the highest officials under the later Mamlūks, had various powers, often including military ones”.

104 GARDINER, “Esotericism in Manuscript Culture”, 287–291.

sufficient unto himself or can find true peerage with any other, for all that we are scions of different stocks. Now I have seen all there is to see, have plumbed the good and the bad, have searched time inside and out, have wandered its deserts in joy and sorrow, and [this I have learned]: discord between brothers but delights one's enemies and saddens one's friends. What say you to concluding a peace that shall neither be transgressed nor ever undone till the end of time, that we may forever be comrades in good times and evil, that *our* friendship, and not that of the boon companions of Jadhīma, shall be for a proverb, and if the twin Calves [of the Polestar] (*al-farqadān*)¹⁰⁵ try to compare themselves to us 'twill be but idle imposture?

You'll find yourself without a brother if you think to find one flawless:
who among men has attained perfection?"¹⁰⁶

Said the sword: "You have judged aright, and unveiled the face of proof; you have taken the highest road and noblest course, and that with success. For you have proposed peace: and peace is best.

May God then unite a pair
who fervently believe they cannot be united?"¹⁰⁷

The two of them then declared [as one]:

"We must find a judge and arbiter to conclude this peace – thus shall we win great honor and advancement. But none will serve our purpose but that perfected lord and most excellent master Abū Yazīd al-Dawādār al-Zāhirī – he of high rank and fearsome bravery, that vast sea and all-succoring rain ... (God Most High multiply his abounding graces and ennoble and elevate him in this world and the next) –, who controls the affairs of the Zahirid state and preserves its order; he is the pole of the kingdom about which it revolves, its fearsome chevalier and terrible lion, ... its impregnable fortress and surest refuge, its most precious centerpiece and costliest jewel, its protector of long standing who knows it entirely and is cognizant of all that is said and done within it, the dragoman who speaks with its tongue, the savant who has mastered its multiplicity, the physician who knows its cure, the helper who heals its pain: it is *he* who shall govern our affair and enlarge our worth, our salvific two-edged sword (*al-ṣā'il min-nā bi-l-ḥaddayn*), our joiner of opposites (*al-jāmi' min-nā bayn al-diddayn*)! ... Praise be to God, Who has joined us together in this most noble and beauteous of stations! Let us therefore have him ratify our treaty, and pledge to him our allegiance as servants and advisors."

¹⁰⁵ I.e., the bright stars Ursa Minor β and γ.

¹⁰⁶ Nābigha, qaṣīda: *atā-nī abayta l-la'na anna-ka lumta-nī / wa-tilka llatī ahtammu min-hā wa-anṣabū*.

¹⁰⁷ Ibn Khafāja, qaṣīda: *la-qad zāra man ahwā 'alā ghayri maw'idin / fa-'āyantu badra l-tammi dhāka l-talāqiyā*.

They proceeded immediately to pen their peace agreement [with the *dawādār* presiding], pledging to one another their mutual compliance and good will. News of this pact was then broadcast by their herald, and their commander spread the announcement of their alliance, singing:

“This peace has destroyed their enemies’ designs
and is published by the tongues of the jealous!”

All feuding and rancor having ceased between them, they entered the dearest of estates and noblest of realms, their conjunction a trine most auspicious (*thallatha qirānu-humā fa-as‘ada*)¹⁰⁸

The standardness of its scenario and literary figures aside, again, al-Qalqashandī’s invocation of the technical term *coincidentia oppositorum*, central concept of contemporary Cairene lettrism, cannot be simply literary in intent. (The concluding astrological reference is a nice touch as well.) Nevertheless, here it is the pen who reconciles with the sword, a common enough outcome in the *munāẓara* tradition to date. It is only in Ibn Turka’s *Debate of Feast and Fight* that the binary is made theoretically explicit—and *cosmically-imperially transcended*.

Ibn Khaldūn’s (Anti-Lettrist) Sword vs. Pen Debate

Another Cairene threw his hat into this ring: Ibn Khaldūn (d. 1406). Characteristically, the Tunisian historian-jurist – a strident anti-occultism polemicist – presses the sword vs. pen theme into his own simple scheme of dynastic cycling, pointedly ignoring the formulations of his fellow Cairene scholars Ibn Turka and al-Qalqashandī.¹⁰⁹ For him sword and pen can never be reconciled; one must always be superior to the other, and the two constantly alternate in their precedence. Thus the sword is supreme only at the beginning and end of a given dynasty’s lifecycle, and the pen only at its height. There can be no equilibrium between them, asserts Ibn Khaldūn; transcendence of the political binary is impossible.¹¹⁰

This formulation is patently reactionary, and like a significant portion of the *Muqaddima* (11 percent, to be precise) testament to the historian’s horror at and dogged opposition to the occult-scientific renaissance then taking place in Cairo

¹⁰⁸ *Ṣubḥ al-a‘shā fī ṣinā‘at al-inshā’*, 14 vols., Cairo: al-Maṭba‘ā al-Amīriyya, 1331–1338/1913–1919, 14/231–240.

¹⁰⁹ On Ibn Khaldūn as reactionary see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “In Defense of Geomancy”.

¹¹⁰ *The Muqaddimah*, 3 vols., trans. Franz Rosenthal, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1967, 2/46–48. See Suhaylā SHUKRĪ, “Jidāl-i bi-pāyān-i qalam u shamshir”, *Kitāb-māh-i tārikh u jughrāfiyā* 114–115 (1386 hš/2007): 80–85.

under the patronage of Barqūq and spearheaded by Akhlāṭī. (That his biographical account of the Mamluk ruler, despite being the fullest produced and based on firsthand experience, is silent as to Barqūq's pronounced occultist interests is likewise telling in this regard.¹¹¹) It should thus be read as part and parcel of Ibn Khaldūn's conservative religio-political project to delegitimize the New Brethren of Purity as emergent ideologues of Islamic imperialism – explicitly theorized by Ibn Turka and Yazdī as the sociopolitical marriage of opposites. That he failed in this project, and his *Muqaddima* was dismissed by contemporary and later historians, is only to be expected: the Ibn Khaldūnian dualist theory of dynastic cycling is flatly antithetical to the needs of millennial sovereigns seeking imperial transcendence.¹¹²

Ibn Turka's *Debate of Feast and Fight*

An abridged translation of Ibn Turka's *Munāẓara-yi bazm u razm* follows, based on my edition of the text.¹¹³ For reasons of space, the middle section, featuring the substance of the debate and comprising just over half of the whole, has here been dropped; it records two full rounds of the debate, beginning with fight's argument with feast and ending with feast's refutation of fight's second volley of proofs. This work is contained in at least eight *majmū'as* now preserved in collections in Iran, Turkey and the United States.¹¹⁴ The colophon of the earliest copy, MS Majlis 10196 ff. 162b-65a, part of a comprehensive *majmū'a* of Ibn Turka's works produced largely during the author's lifetime and featuring the autographs of Ibn Turka and Yazdī, states: "Completed on 25 Rabī' II 829 [6 March 1426] in Herat (God protect her from plague)". That is to say, this work was pro-

111 On Ibn Khaldūn as a member of Barqūq's court – whence his intimate familiarity with the Brethren's occultist program – see Walter J. FISCHER, *Ibn Khaldūn in Egypt: His Public Functions and His Historical Research (1382–1406): A Study in Islamic Historiography*, Berkeley: University of California Press, 1967, 71–81.

112 See MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "In Defense of Geomancy". The irony here, of course, is that Ibn Khaldūn himself – with not a little hypocrisy – hailed Temür a Lord of Conjunction during his famous interview with the conqueror in Damascus. On the modest reception of the *Muqaddima* in later Ottoman historiography, i.e., well after the Süleymanic model of millennial sovereignty had been retired, see Cornell FLEISCHER, "Royal Authority, Dynastic Cyclism, and 'Ibn Khaldūnism' in Sixteenth-Century Ottoman Letters", *Journal of Asian and African Studies* 18/3–4 (1983): 198–220.

113 Again, for the edition and a full translation see my forthcoming *The Lettrist Treatises of Ibn Turka*.

114 See MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "The Quest", 101–102.

duced in the Timurid capital when Ibn Turka was again facing inquisition after being denounced by jealous scholarly opponents in the Shafi'i qadi's native Fars. Its dedication to Bāysunghur is here significant: that prince would seem to have been one of Ibn Turka's chief patrons and defenders, addressee of the latter's second apology (*Nafsat al-maṣdūr-i duvvum*) in the wake of his third, and disastrous, trial of 1427.¹¹⁵

In the name of God, all-merciful, ever merciful.

Boundless praise be to the King, the radiance of whose sword (*tigh*) of staggering majesty exalts the sway of His glory on the battlefield (*razmgāh*) of our inborn nature (*fiṭrat-i ūlā*) – having deftly split the pen (*qalam*) of fate it inscribes its lines on the mirrored surface of the worlds, and from the soft scratching of its inscription echoes the claxon of creation across the tracts of the world of generation and corruption, the feasthall (*bazmgāh*) of primordial totality (*jam'iyyat-i aṣlī*); and excellent and pure blessings be strewn before the holy court of the master of creation and choicest of creatures,

Muḥammad, on whose dust the world is drunk –
a thousand thousand blessings on his pure soul –

that leader who perpetuates the blessed arcadian abodes with the verdant mead of his greenshining blade and keeps ever moist the eternal gardens of paradise with the wet glint of his sword – his Hindu blade, bought like a slave, having kissed his hand won preeminence among all peoples ('*arab u 'ajam*), and his discomfited sword, trembling with nakedness, through the succor of his fame turned worldconquering (*jahān-gushāy*).

You lift up your blade against the pen's face
for the blade's sentence is to be carried out on its head.

God bless him, his family, his companions, his wives, his seed after him. Those who remember will remember, though the heedless forget.

To proceed: Last night when the pen of fate inscribed *He wraps the day about the night* (Q 39:5) upon the page of time and the arm of morning with its sunsword routed with resplendent hand the forces of evening, the black scrawls of darkness were wiped from the dayrecord at the instance of the master of time; the sharpness of the sunblade having communicated to the black regime of night via the royal administration's messenger the verse *The last remnant of the people that worked darkness was cut off* (Q 6:45),¹¹⁶ it caused it to flee. The blackness of the grand *muḥaqqaq* script-down (*khattī*) on the delightful cheek

¹¹⁵ See n. 71 above. This impression is confirmed by three letters from Ibn Turka to Bāysunghur preserved in the *Munsha'āt-i Turka*, which testify to a warm relationship (MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "The Quest", 141), as well as by Bāysunghur's status as chief patron to the preeminent poet Kātibi, Ibn Turka's student (ibid., 53–55).

¹¹⁶ The author here plays on the root meaning of *ẓulm*, normally translated 'oppression', which is darkness (*ẓalām*, *ẓulma*).

of day having cast up dust was scraped-shaved clean and the rust of darkness which had drained the color from the face of the pure bladebody of the sun polished away –

The blade of the world-delighting sun
has severed the head of night from the body of day.¹¹⁷

My imagination (*khayāl*) – that solacer of those awander in the deserts of privation and companion to those pained by exile – was thereat inspired to employ its perfected painterly skills to body forth a debate between feast and fight (*munāẓara-yi bazm u razm*) upon the tablets of discourse; and since the subtle figures of its exposition suggested that such an undertaking would serve a purpose, it seemed requisite to record this debate in written form so as to provide serious seekers with a fresh offering.

Beginning of the Debate between Feast and Fight

Late last night, as the gray glimmers of predawn began to play on the horizon and the signs of opposition and war (*muqābala u muqātala*) between the world's Faridūn, sultan of high noon, and the glittering army of the Siyāvush of night became manifest on the pages of time, Heart (*dil*) – emperor of the twin realms of body and spirit encompassed by human nature – set out for the abode of totality that is its primordial home (*jam'īyyat-khāna-yi aṣli-yi khwīsh*), wherein all opposites embrace (*ta'ānuq-i mutaḳābilāt*) and all rivals are well met (*taṣāfuḥ-i sāyir-i aẓdād u andād*).

When you return to the transcendence (*bī-rangī*) that once you had
you find even Moses and Pharaoh have made peace.¹¹⁸

In Him I am you, we are you, you are Him:
all is in *He is He* – just ask those who've arrived!¹¹⁹

In gazing upon the portico of that all-encompassing palace, Heart saw that it was hosting – according to the dictum *The sultan is the shadow of God* (ẓill Allāh) [on earth] – a conversation between two groups, the worthy retainers of Commander Majesty (*qahramān-i jalāl*) on the one hand and the cultured intimates of the inner court of Grace and Beauty (*ḥarīm-i luṭf u jamāl*) on the other, whose verbal repartee filled time and space; when it listened closely and carefully observed, Heart discerned it to be a formal debate between the factions Feast and Fight, each following the established rules of the genre and making its case by turns.

Rare elegance in all testifies to a pith of wisdom.

117 Niẓāmī, *Khusraw u Shīrīn*, pt. 15: 'ishrat-i Khusraw dar marghzār u siyāsati Hurmuz. On such poetic oppositional light-dark imagery in the Mughal (i.e., Indo-Timurid) context, and its roots in Ibn Turkian letrism, see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "Of Islamic Grammatology".

118 Mawlavī (Rūmī), *Maṣnavī-yi ma'navī*, book 1, part 121 (ed. Muḥammad Istī'lāmī, 7 vols., Tehran: Zavvār, 1369–1375 hš/1990–1995, Vol. 1, l. 2479).

119 This verse from Ibn 'Arabī's nonextant *al-Manāzil al-insāniyya* is quoted in 'Abd al-Razzāq KĀSHĀNĪ's *Iṣtilāḥāt al-ṣūfiyya*, ed. 'Abd al-'Āl Shāhīn, Cairo: Dār al-Manār, 1413/1992, 82. The immediately preceding verse, commonly quoted in exposition of the technical term 'high letters' (*ḥurūf-i 'ālīyāt*): *kunnā ḥurūfan 'ālīyātin lam nuqal / muta'allaqātin fī dhurā a'lā l-qulal*.

However much Fight would found its arguments on rational and traditional proofs, brandishing the wielders of the sword and of the pen (*a'vân-i sayf u qalam*) as its right and left wings, Feast would counter with piercing wit, lilting beguiling songs and declaiming speeches alternately playful and censorious, thereby striving to overwhelm its competition.

Refined taste (*zawq*) exerts its might and main:
one can't expect to safely outlast it.

[Here follows *Fight's Argument against Feast*; *Feast's Answer to Fight*; *Fight's Refutation of Feast's Proofs*; and *Feast's Refutation of Fight's Proofs*]

Sultan Love Is Informed of the Debate and Judges between Fight and Feast

The clamor generated by this contentious debate and its intense repartees – whereby every proof put forward by the warriors of Fight was mockingly dismissed with a witty barb by the silvertongued orators of Feast, and every rational and traditional argument made by the first countered by the second with flights of fancy and poetical conceits – finally reached such a pitch that it came to the notice of the truthserving attendants of the throne within the pavilion of the absolute sovereign Love. They accordingly reported to the sultan that the members of his state apparatus (*mulāzimān-i ayvān-i saltanat*), who constitute His Majesty's encompassing shadow (*zill-i zalil*) [throughout the earth], had divided themselves into two factions contending together in a debate that had become so heated as to feature insults and mutual abuse. The sultan therefore dispatched his vizier, Reason (*'aql*), and his commander, Intuition (*zawq*), to carefully study the matter together and render their report, which they did in dutiful obedience to the world emperor (*jahān-muṭā*).

Thereupon he issued this judgment: The pillars of the workshop that is Fight are the foundation upon which empire (*saltanat*) is built. A sultan cannot for a single instant fail to care for the members of this faction, the wielders of sword and of pen: for the affairs of state and religion can be sustained only through their training and advancement, and – as is evident from the dictum *Kingship and religion are twins* (*al-mulk wa-l-dīn taw'amān*)¹²⁰ – the very basis of rule and government and justice cannot perdure save through their unstinting sponsorship by the sultan. According to [lettrist] analysis (*taḥqīq*),¹²¹ moreover, empire

120 Cf. Ikhwān al-Ṣafā', *Rasā'il*, 2/310: *inna l-dīn wa-l-mulk akhawān taw'amān*. Or as Sanā'ī puts it in his *Ḥadiqat al-ḥaqīqa wa-sharī'at al-ṭarīqa* (ed. M. Mudarris Raḡavī, 2 vols., Tehran: Sipihr, 1329 hš/1950, 1/583): *chashm-i sar mulk u chashm-i sirr dīn ast / ān jahān-bīn va īn nihān-bīn ast // īn va ān har dū yār-i yak-digar-and / ham khazān ham bahār-i yak-digar-and*. That is:

The head's eye is kingship, the heart's eye religion:
one beholds the visible world, the other beholds the unseen.
They are each the other's lover,
their spring and their autumn the same.

In his *Arznāma* Jalāl al-Dīn Davānī invokes this saying to describe the Akquyunlu corps of religious scholars and sayyids as the spiritual army (*lashkar-i ma'navī*) counterbalancing the physical army (*lashkar-i šūrī*) (ed. Īraj Afshār, Tehran: n. p., 1335 hš/1956, 15; on the lettrist argument Davānī offers in the preface to the same work see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, *The Occult Science of Empire*).

121 As noted, while the term *taḥqīq* was certainly used by contemporary and later scholars in

denotes the perfect ordering of that form and totality associated with the [divine] name the Manifest (*ẓāhir*) and its officers and attendants; therefore both of these groups, whose hands and tongues are responsible for most of the formal properties of empire and whose pens and feet responsible for its proper ordering, are a *sine qua non* of sovereignty (*mulk u pādshāhī*).

Honor penmen (*qalam-zan*) and swordmen (*shamshir-zan*),
not chanteuse (*muṭrib*): for manliness is not of women (*zan*).¹²²

Now true members of the circle of Feast do not glory in mere jesting (*hazl*), but continually discourse on the sciences of the real (*‘ulūm-i ḥaqīqī*) and the perfection of the soul (*kamāl-i naḥsānī*), citing the refined comportment (*ādāb*) and essayings (*tajriba-hā*) of the great men of days gone by; they too are a *sine qua non* of sovereignty, whose role begins once the business of ordering the empire has been properly realized.

Purchase a desire with patience,
purchase peace of mind with repose.¹²³

Yet there are also some among them (I take refuge in God!) obsessed with illicit entertainments, supposing them to be attractive [to the powerful] and hoping thereby to gain intimacy with the members of the court of Majesty; such fall far far short of their mark, and expose themselves to much danger.

You’re besotted with beauties’ beauty?
Just wait: that’s not beauty.
You need but *one second* to wake up—
not a day, a week, a month, a year.¹²⁴

These have their counterparts among the folk of Fight, who parade their embroidered oratory and glory in empty speech, thereby seeking advancement. But they too forsake their true business: among humankind, it is their office to work diligently, and to recognize this as the sole basis for their claims to honor – certainly not their mere facility with eloquent and poetic discourse.

This is how one becomes a servant of kings:
one speaks not – all is deed.
This is how the nightingale, silly drunk, becomes a prisoner caged:
it does not – all is speech.

the more generic sense of ‘independent verification’, Ibn Turka, Yazdī and their fellow Brethren consistently employ it in a technical, lettrist sense. On “*taḥqīqism*” as representative of Western early modernity more broadly, see Matthew MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “*Taḥqīq vs. Taqlīd* in the Renaissance of Western Early Modernity”, *Philological Encounters* 3/1 (2018): 193–249.

122 Sa’dī, *Būstān*, ch. 1: *dar ‘adl u tadbīr u rāy: guftār dar dīldārī-yi hunarmandān*.

123 Nizāmī, *Khusraw u Shīrīn*, pt. 41: *murād-i ṭalabīdan-i Khusraw az Shīrīn u mānī’ shudan-i ū*.

124 Awḥadī, *qaṣīda: mastān-i kh‘āb-rā khabarī az viṣāl nīst*.

[By contrast], such elevated discourse is the basis for the folk of Feast's claims to honor; yet for them to enter into debate with the partisans of Form (*şūrat*), thereby seeking preferment, is most inappropriate to their position, and indeed shameful and obscene. For they are the officers and attendants of the court of the Occult (*buṭūn*), and so have more to do with the members of the sultan's privy council (*ahl-i sirr*); it is imperative that they not disclose what transpires at private sessions (*majlis-i khāṣṣ*) or enter freely into debate and discussion with just anyone, lest they damage the confidential nature of such sessions and forfeit royal intimacy (*majālis-i uns*). As [the poet] has sung:

I call a boon companion one who observes
that protocol you and I know so well:
Mine eye does not pasture on saki's face,
mine ear does not steal secret speech.¹²⁵

Reason Asks of His Majesty Love the Reason for Feast and Fight's Special Preferment

Upon hearing this speech by His Majesty the sultan and seeing the great importance he assigned the matter, Vizier Reason approached, making obeisance, and humbly asked: "What is the distinction of these two groups among all the inhabitants of the world that they thus merit such royal solicitude and are awarded such noble privilege and care?

The whole world waits to see who will win
the favored glance: it might suddenly land on you!¹²⁶

For truly, despite the fact that ardent worshipers in the hermitages of privation and piety and the very angels of heaven (*muqarrabān-i mala' i a'lā*) have thrown themselves in the dust of your world-encompassing threshold, there burning with desire [for Your Majesty's favor], none have ever attained the felicity of that royal solicitude shown these two groups or been granted such access.

Everyone has their own path. But why should Farhād sharpen his ax
when Khusraw already enjoys a sumptuous feast?"

Sultan Love Explains Why He Specially Prefers Feast and Fight

Thereupon His Majesty responded in this wise: "The secret of their preferment may be learned from the exponents of the school of *And He taught with the Pen* (Q 96:4),¹²⁷ and the letters (*hurūf*) of these [two] terms descried on the reality-revealing Tablet *And He taught you what you knew not* (Q 4:113).

Only the Sun can drown out the stars:
your little lamp can hardly make it day.

125 Anvarī, *Divān*, *muqaṭṭa'a* 480, ll. 4, 10: *har ān-gah ki chūn man nayāyad nakh'ānī*.

126 Sa'dī, *Divān*, ghazal 584: *hargaz ān dīl bi-namirad ki tū jān-ash bāshī*.

127 The quranic phrase (*W'LMBALQLM*) equals 249.

For those familiar with this school, they must first consider the *HM* (= 48) of Muḥammad (God's blessings and peace be upon him); then, having hearkened to the dictum [in *Sūrat Yūsuf*] *I saw eleven stars* (Q 12:4) and therefore aware of the method for adjusting (*taqvīm*) these Josephian stars (*kavākib yūsufī*; *KWKB* = 48), they may discern in what [the terms] Feast (*bazm*; *BZM* = 49) and Fight (*razm*; *RZM* = 247)¹²⁸ are the same and in what different. Thus will the wise learn the secret of my discourse (*ḥarf*).¹²⁹

What I have uttered is but a hint; if you're clever
you'll derive the rest from your own experience.
Anyone who realizes some part of this pithy allusion
will test his silver – and find even his gravel turned precious stone.
And I have already simplified my discourse by ten degrees
that perchance understanding will enter your brain!¹³⁰

The Reason for Incorporating This [Lettrist] Analysis (*taḥqīq*) in an Allegory (*majāz*)

It is evident that – according to the dictum *the basest of men is he who eats alone* (*sharr al-nās man akala waḥda-hu*)¹³¹ – those who have been blessed with divine grace and heavenly favor and attained to the new wine from the gardens of the universal Effluxion and its everlasting munificence have little choice but to communicate somewhat of it to their contemporaries and peers to the extent they are able, giving them to taste thereof, thereby fulfilling the divine injunction *And as for your Lord's blessing, declare it* (Q 93:11). And no wonder!

When the Tartar roe grazes on the beflowered mead
the breeze bears the scent of musk to market.¹³²

Hence the present treatise – a nosegay from the garden of intimacy to bedeck the majlis of the new generation (*naw-khāstagān-i vaqt*). I therefore purposed to include therein the freshest bud of the age and its newest wine, to provide seekers a whiff of the fragrant breezes wafting from out the inner chamber of intimacy: the science of letter (*'ilm-i ḥarf*). Virginal, secluded daughter of the House of Prophecy and Sacral Power (*mukhaddara-yi khānavāda-yi nubuvvat u valāyat*), [until recently] none had beheld her gorgeous face; [this science] is peculiar to our own noble age.

128 In the margin: 2 200 47.

129 While I have been unable to divine Ibn Turka's lettrist point here, it is clear he considers it to clinch his argument as a whole.

130 Awḥadī, *Divān*, qaṣīda 16, ll. 5, 25, 29: *rūzī qarār u qā'ida-yi mā digar shavad*.

131 Cf. Akhlāṭī's letter to Ibn Turka as preserved at the beginning of MS Majlis 10196, which features a lettrist meditation on the same maxim, deployed to urge his protégé to write a summary work on lettrism – the *K. al-Mafāḥiṣ* (see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "The Quest", 568–569).

132 Nizāmī, *Khusraw u Shirīn*, part 64: *ṣifat-i dād u diḥish-i Khusraw*.

Circle her mouth like sugar, for today
 that shipment of sugar from which sugar is shipped – 'tis her!
 That moonface, the worshipers at whose gate
 bear away their prayer rug and rosary to the vintner – 'tis her!¹³³

It was accordingly deemed imperative to provide a lettrist point in the treatise to illustrate [to my contemporaries the science's] peculiar properties and effects, God Almighty alone willing, this through the sanctity of Muḥammad and his House (God's blessings and peace be upon him and them all).

Completed on 25 Rabi' II 829 [6 March 1426] in Herat (God protect her from plague).

Conclusion: The *Coincidentia Oppositorum* Imperialized

Ibn Turka's gorgeous oeuvre and influential career as ideologue of Islamic imperial universalism – his *Debate of Feast and Fight* being a double case in point – robustly substantiates Shahab AHMED's central argument in his landmark *What Is Islam?* That argument in brief: Islamic civilization, more than any other before or since, was characterized by its total embrace of *contradiction* and *ambiguity* as organizing principles for society and culture; thus Islam has been *historically lived as paradox*.

Paradox is perhaps *the* definitive conceptual device in the discourses of the Sufi-philosophical amalgam of the Balkans-to-Bengal complex that engage with the fundamental dilemma of the incorrigible relationship that obtains in an emanationist cosmology between transcendence and immanence ... The discourse of the school of Ibn 'Arabī which lies at the conceptual heart of this amalgam is riven through by *coincidentia oppositorum* (Arabic: *jam' al-aqdād*).¹³⁴

The prolific scale at which and idiomatic virtuosity with which Muslims' literary discourses employ paradox ... as well as the fundamental nature of the subject matter for which paradox is used, demonstrate for us the centrality of paradox to the processes of *meaning-making in terms of Islam*. I am, of course, not suggesting that other discursive communities do not use paradox but am rather pointing out that ... the crucial difference with regard to Islam is that of *centrality* and *scale*.¹³⁵

¹³³ Awḥādī, *Divān*, ghazal 111: *sarvī ki az-ū va ḥūr va parī bār barand ū-st*.

¹³⁴ Shahab AHMED, *What Is Islam?*, 398.

¹³⁵ Ibid., 401.

[T]o live with outright contradiction, as societies of Muslims historically have done, one must be able to conceive of contradiction in terms of one's paradigmatic values and truths ... History shows us that Muslims have done this by effectively recognizing that the phenomenon of Revelation necessarily generates (Islamic) Truth and Meaning in two main spatially-differentiated trajectories, namely, *hierarchy*, and *interiority/exteriority*.¹³⁶

Put simply: the historical development of Islamicate culture in general and that of the post-Mongol Persian cosmopolis in particular would appear to map neatly onto the quranic dictum *He is the First and the Last, the Manifest and the Occult*.

So argued Ibn Turka and his occultist colleagues; this was, as we have seen, the primary motto and rallying call of the New Brethren of Purity. The Isfahani lettrist's importance to Islamic intellectual and cultural history thus centers on his status as the first thinker to systematize the Ibn 'Arabian doctrine of the *majma' al-aqdād*¹³⁷ within a rigorous neopythagorean-neoplatonic framework (this in the *Book of Inquiries*), then disseminate the same in a series of attractive yet accessible Persian treatises for his royal patrons, thereby making it immediately *usable* by sultan-scientist and prince-calligrapher alike.¹³⁸ (Ibn 'Arabi's own formulations, of course, are far too scattered, dense and unsystematic to easily serve this purpose.) In this he stands as rather precise cognate to such European Renaissance sages as Nicholas of Cusa (d. 1464), his later contemporary and fellow neopythagoreanizer, who indeed coined the Latin term *coincidentia oppositorum* itself;¹³⁹ Giovanni Pico della Mirandola (d. 1494), reconciler of Plato and Aristotle

¹³⁶ Ibid., 404. See also Thomas BAUER, *Die Kultur der Ambiguität*, Berlin: Verlag der Weltreligionen, 2011.

¹³⁷ Toshihiko IZUTSU observes on this point: "In Ibn 'Arabi's world view ... the world of Being cannot be grasped in its true form except as a synthesis of contradictions. Only by a simultaneous affirmation of contradictories can we understand the real nature of the world ... The Absolute ... cannot be grasped except in the form of *coincidentia oppositorum*. Ibn 'Arabi quotes in support of his view a famous saying of Abū Sa'īd al-Kharraz, a great mystic of Baghdad of the ninth century: 'God cannot be known except as a synthesis of opposites'" (*Sufism and Taoism: A Comparative Study of Key Philosophical Concepts*, Berkeley: University of California Press, 1983, 74–75; quoted in AHMED, *What Is Islam?*, 398 n. 199).

¹³⁸ I have elsewhere proposed Ibn Turkian lettrism as the immediate theoretical context for the emergence of Persianate book culture and visual culture, as well as for the mathematization of astronomy at the Samarkand Observatory; it is not an accident that both cultural processes began in Timurid Iran (see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, "Of Islamic Grammatology" and idem, "Powers of One"). On the warm reception of Ibn Turka's and Davānī's lettrism by Safavid philosophers in particular see idem, "World as (Arabic) Text".

¹³⁹ See in particular David ALBERTSON, *Mathematical Theologies: Nicholas of Cusa and the Legacy of Thierry of Chartres*, New York: Oxford University Press, 2014.

and father of Christian kabbalah as core of humanism;¹⁴⁰ and especially John Dee (d. 1609), occult philosopher and imperial ideologue to Queen Elizabeth I (r. 1558–1603) – to this end coining the term ‘Brytish Impier’ –, whose central project was likewise to decipher the “cabala of the real.”¹⁴¹

What AHMED glosses over, however, and what such comparisons obscure, is the fact that in Ibn Turka’s hands the concept of contradiction – that mighty engine of Islamic civilization to a degree far greater than Christian – was explicitly, definitively and ornately recast in *occult-scientific* and *imperialist-universalist* terms. This occultist imperialist discourse is epitomized by his *Munāẓara-yi bazm u razm* and the other works he wrote for ambitious members of the Timurid ruling elite, including Iskandar Sulṭān, Shāhrukh, Bāysunghur and Ulugh Beg; therein he seeks to refashion his patrons as saint-philosopher-kings, transcendent of all religiopolitical and indeed geographical duality, matrices of henological empire, and faithful scions of their (grand)father Temür, a Letterlord and Starlord in equal measure.¹⁴² That is to say: in the Balkans-to-Bengal complex, from the early 15th century onward, *contradiction as concept is indissociable from lettrism, and lettrism indissociable from empire*.

If this basic fact is not taken into account, if the writings of lettrists like Ibn Turka continue to be disappeared into mere *mysticism*, early modern Islamic imperialism itself – Timurid, Aqquyunlu, Mughal, Safavid and Ottoman – must remain theoretically illegible. For how else can we do full justice to the historical feature that most distinguishes that imperialism from both caliphal-sultanic precedent and its European successors: radical ecumenism, an alarming (to certain conservative religious-scholarly observers) embrace of legal, confessional and ethnic contradictions?¹⁴³ Such millennial sovereigns and successors to Temür as Sultan Süleymān, the Lawgiver, last world emperor and second Solomon, tran-

140 See e.g. Chaim WIRSZUBSKI, *Pico della Mirandola’s Encounter with Jewish Mysticism*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1989.

141 See e.g. Håkan HÅKANSSON, *Seeing the Word: John Dee and Renaissance Occultism*, Lund: Lunds Universitet, 2001; MELVIN-KOUSHKI, “Powers of One”. For a comparative analysis of Dee’s occult-scientific imperialist project vis-à-vis its (far more successful) early modern Islamic cognates see my forthcoming *The Occult Science of Empire*, introduction.

142 Unlike *ṣāhib-qirān*, the title *ṣāhib-hurūf*, translated here as Letterlord, does not appear in the sources as such; I use it as a heuristic for flagging the equal importance of lettrist arguments to the construction of Timurid imperial ideology.

143 Premodern agrarian empires, of course, were willy-nilly ecumenical as a matter of pragmatic state policy, for reasons structural, economic, demographic and geographic; but the radical forms of ecumenism that so distinguish early modern Islamic empires from their increasingly radically anti-ecumenical contemporary and subsequent Christian cognates were also unprecedentedly and explicitly *ideological* in tenor, being driven by the brand of occult-scientific im-

scended the binaries of *sharīʿa* and *yasa*, of Islamdom and Christendom, of Asia and Europe; and Emperor Akbar, solar prophet-king and supreme Lord of Conjunction, promulgator of Universal Harmony (*ṣulḥ-i kull*) and object of worship, transcended the binaries of Islam and Hinduism, monotheism and trinitarianism, cyclicalism and eschaton, heaven and earth.¹⁴⁴

In sum: Ibn Turka's seminal philosophical-scientific works on lettrism aside, even those of his treatises that are more strictly literary in tenor stand as index of this dramatic shift in post-Mongol Islamic imperial ideology – as well as the unconscionable neglect in scholarship to date of sources of the closest pertinence to this theme. His *Debate of Feast and Fight* is here representative, an ornate Persian work that expressly imperializes the venerable *razm u bazm* and sword vs. pen tropes within a lettrist-literary framework, that marries Arabic-Mamluk literary culture to Persian-Timurid, that recasts the *munāẓara* as philosophical romance and the philosophical romance as mirror for princes, that makes explicit the logic of the *coincidentia oppositorum* long implicit in the genre in order to ideologically weaponize it. For the first time in the centuries-old Arabo-Persian *munāẓara* tradition, that is, wherein such debates were often rhetorically but never theoretically resolved, Ibn Turka *marries multiple opposites* in a manner clearly meant to be instructive to his Timurid royal patron: he too is to perform the role of Emperor Love, transcendent of all political-legal dualities, avatar of the Manifest and the Occult. This lettrist mirror for Timurid princes is thus not simply unprecedented in Persian or indeed Arabic literature, a typical expression of the ornate literary panache and genre-hybridizing proclivities of Mamluk-Timurid-Ottoman scientists of letters, and index of the burgeoning of Ibn ʿArabian-Būnian lettrism in late Mamluk Cairo; it also serves as key to Timurid universalist imperial ideology itself in its formative phase. For it sings of Amir Temür, greatest of Muslim *ṣāhib-qirāns*, whose Turko-Mongol successors achieved empire by feasting and fighting, whose imperial love was historically talismanic.

perial universalism examined here. On this theme see MELVIN-KOUSHKI, *The Occult Science of Empire*.

144 See idem, “Early Modern Islamicate Empire”; and n. 56 above.